Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 10 · DAYS 302-333

Wisdom Literature

Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Solomon

How to live in God's world. Wisdom, meaning, and love as covenant life.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

Psalms 19 and 119 beside Proverbs. Psalms 49 and 73 beside Ecclesiastes. Psalm 45 beside the Song of Solomon.

UNIT 10

In this unit

WEEK 44

302	Proverbs 1:1-2:22	*Reading*
303	Proverbs 3:1-4:27	*Reading*
304	Proverbs 5:1-6:35	*Reading*
305	Psalm 19	*Psalm*
306	Psalm 119:1-40	*Psalm*
307	Proverbs 7:1-8:36	*Reading*
308	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 45

309	Proverbs 9:1-11:31	*Reading*
310	Proverbs 12:1-14:35	*Reading*
311	Psalm 119:41-96	*Psalm*
312	Proverbs 15:1-17:28	*Reading*
313	Proverbs 18:1-19:29	*Reading*
314	Proverbs 20:1-21:31	*Reading*
315	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 46

316	Proverbs 22:1-24:34	*Reading*
317	Psalm 119:97-144	*Psalm*
318	Proverbs 25:1-27:27	*Reading*
319	Proverbs 28:1-29:27	*Reading*
320	Proverbs 30:1-31:31	*Reading*
321	Ecclesiastes 1:1-2:26	*Reading*
322	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 47

323	Ecclesiastes 3:1-4:16	*Reading*

324	Psalm 49	*Psalm*
325	Psalm 73	*Psalm*
326	Ecclesiastes 5:1-7:29	*Reading*
327	Ecclesiastes 8:1-10:20	*Reading*
328	Ecclesiastes 11:1-12:14	*Reading*
329	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 48

330	Song of Solomon 1:1-4:16	*Reading*
331	Song of Solomon 5:1-8:14	*Reading*
332	Psalm 45	*Psalm*
333	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 302 · WEEK 44

Proverbs 1:1-2:22

The purpose of Proverbs; wisdom's call; the two paths

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 1:1-2:22. These chapters introduce the whole book. Read the opening statement of purpose slowly, then listen to the voice of Wisdom crying out in the street.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Proverbs is a collection of wise sayings, largely associated with Solomon, gathered over generations in Israel. It is not a book of promises or laws. It is practical instruction on how to live well in God's world, written mostly as a father speaking to his son. The first nine chapters form an extended introduction, urging the reader to choose wisdom over folly. You have just read the story of Solomon, who asked for wisdom and then lost his way. Now you read the wisdom itself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The book is for "learning about wisdom and instruction, for understanding words of insight" (1:2).
2. "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction" (1:7).
3. "Hear, my son, your father's instruction, and forsake not your mother's teaching" (1:8).
4. Sinners entice: "Come with us... let us ambush the blameless" (1:10-19).
5. "Wisdom cries aloud in the street, in the markets she raises her voice" (1:20).
6. "Whoever listens to me will dwell secure and will be at ease, without dread of disaster" (1:33).

7. “For the LORD gives wisdom; from his mouth come knowledge and understanding” (2:6).

8. Wisdom will deliver “from the way of evil” and “from the forbidden woman” (2:12, 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening sentence of Proverbs sets the agenda. This is a book about skill in living: how to handle money, words, friendships, work, sex, and anger in a way that fits the world as God made it. The Hebrew word for wisdom means practical skill, like the skill of a craftsman. Wisdom is not first about being clever. It is about being rightly aligned.

Verse 7 is the key to the whole book: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge.” To fear the LORD is to take him seriously as God, to live in reverent awe and trust before him. It is not terror but a right orientation. Everything else in the book flows from it. A person can be intelligent and still be a fool if he leaves God out. The beginning point of wisdom is not information, but a relationship.

The book is delivered as a father’s teaching, and the father warns his son about the pull of the crowd. The sinners’ invitation is attractive: easy money and belonging. But Proverbs says the gang is heading for a trap, “lying in wait for their own blood.” The hardest part of the lesson is that sin often looks like a shortcut.

Wisdom is then personified as a woman crying aloud in the street. She is not hidden. She calls in the markets and at the gates. The tragedy is that people do not listen. When disaster comes, she says, “I will laugh at your calamity,” meaning that those who refused every invitation are left to what they chose. But those who listen “will dwell secure.”

Chapter 2 gives the path to wisdom: receive the words, treasure the commands, call out for insight, and seek it like silver. And it gives the source: “The LORD gives wisdom.” We do not find wisdom by ourselves. We ask for it, and God gives it. The chapter ends with two ways: the path of the upright, who will dwell in the land, and the way of the wicked, who will be cut off.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that Christ became to us “wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification and redemption” (1 Corinthians 1:30), and that in him “are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge” (Colossians 2:3). James 1:5 invites us to ask God for wisdom. Jesus himself taught in the manner of the wise, with parables and sayings, and said the wise man builds on the rock (Matthew 7:24).

STEP 6

Application

Ask God for wisdom today, as the passage urges. Name one decision where you need it.

Think about the voices that invite you to take a shortcut. Which one is loudest right now?

Treat the fear of the LORD as a starting point and not an extra.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to begin wisdom in you by the fear of him.
- Ask him to keep you from the way of the crowd.
- Tell him where you most need wisdom this week.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 303 · WEEK 44

Proverbs 3:1-4:27

Trust the LORD; the value of wisdom; guard your heart

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 3:1-4:27. These chapters contain the unit's anchor, Proverbs 3:5-6. Read it slowly in its setting, and notice how the father urges his son to guard his heart.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The father continues his instruction to his son in a series of short lessons. Chapter 3 gives commands about trust, honor, and discipline, along with promises of life and favor. Chapter 4 recalls the father's own teaching from his father, passing wisdom from generation to generation. These chapters hold some of the best-known verses of the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Let not steadfast love and faithfulness forsake you; bind them around your neck; write them on the tablet of your heart" (3:3).
2. "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding" (3:5).
3. "In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths" (3:6).
4. "Be not wise in your own eyes; fear the LORD, and turn away from evil" (3:7).
5. "Honor the LORD with your wealth and with the firstfruits of all your produce" (3:9).
6. "My son, do not despise the LORD's discipline or be weary of his reproof, for the LORD reproves him whom he loves, as a father the son in whom he delights" (3:11-12).
7. "Blessed is the one who finds wisdom, and the one who gets understanding" (3:13).
8. "Keep your heart with all vigilance, for from it flow the springs of life" (4:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The center of the passage is 3:5-6, a call to total trust. “With all your heart” means with the whole inner person, without holding back. And its opposite is leaning on your own understanding. This is not a call to stop thinking. It is a call to stop treating our own judgment as the final authority. We often feel certain, and we are often wrong. The alternative is to “acknowledge him in all your ways,” to bring God into every decision, large and small. The promise is that “he will make straight your paths.” It does not mean a life without difficulty, but a life that God directs.

The chapter then moves through practical areas. Money: honor the LORD with the firstfruits. Discipline: do not resent it. The father’s note on discipline is among the most important in the book: God reproves those he loves, “as a father the son in whom he delights.” Hardship, correction, and loss are not signs that God has abandoned us. They are signs that we have a Father.

Wisdom is then praised in glowing terms. She is better than silver and gold, more precious than jewels. “Her ways are ways of pleasantness, and all her paths are peace.” She is “a tree of life to those who lay hold of her.” And the writer points to creation: “The LORD by wisdom founded the earth.” The wisdom we are offered is the same wisdom by which the world was made.

Chapter 4 adds the generational dimension and the famous warning to guard the heart. The heart is the source of everything: words, eyes, feet. If the spring is polluted, the stream is polluted. The path of the righteous is “like the light of dawn, which shines brighter and brighter until full day,” while the way of the wicked is like deep darkness.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus trusted the Father completely, even to death, saying, “Not my will, but yours, be done” (Luke 22:42). Hebrews 12:5-11 quotes Proverbs 3:11-12 to teach how God disciplines his children as a Father. John 1:3 and Colossians 1:16 show Christ as the one through whom the world was made, the wisdom of God. Jesus said, “I am the light of the world” (John 8:12), the one who leads us into the full day.

STEP 6

Application

Take Proverbs 3:5-6 with you. Write it somewhere you will see it.

Name one area where you lean on your own understanding. Give it to God.

If you are going through a hard season, ask whether the Father may be correcting you in love.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you lean on your own understanding and give it to him.
- Ask him to make your paths straight.
- Thank him that his discipline is love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 304 · WEEK 44

Proverbs 5:1-6:35

Warnings against adultery; practical wisdom

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 5:1-6:35. The father warns his son about adultery and gives a series of practical warnings about debt, laziness, and the things God hates. Read these as pastoral warnings, not just rules.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The father's warnings about sexual temptation are among the most frequent in Proverbs 1 to 9. They reflect the danger to a young man in a world where seductive voices were everywhere. Chapter 6 widens the scope to financial foolishness, laziness, and a list of seven things the LORD hates. The advice is frank, and it assumes that desire is powerful and must be directed.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The lips of a forbidden woman drip honey, and her speech is smoother than oil, but in the end she is bitter as wormwood" (5:3-4).
2. "Keep your way far from her, and do not go near the door of her house" (5:8).
3. "Drink water from your own cistern, flowing water from your own well" (5:15).
4. "Let your fountain be blessed, and rejoice in the wife of your youth" (5:18).
5. "For a man's ways are before the eyes of the LORD, and he ponders all his paths" (5:21).
6. "Go to the ant, O sluggard; consider her ways, and be wise" (6:6).
7. "There are six things that the LORD hates, seven that are an abomination to him" (6:16).
8. "For the commandment is a lamp and the teaching a light, and the reproofs of discipline are the way of life" (6:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first warning is not a prudish one. The father admits that the seductive woman's speech is smooth and sweet. The temptation is real. But "in the end she is bitter as wormwood." The pattern of sin is a sweet start and a bitter end. The wise person looks at the end first.

The practical advice is to keep far away: "Do not go near the door of her house." Wisdom does not test how close it can get. It flees. It is a principle that applies far beyond sexual sin: the way to avoid falling is to avoid the places where one is likely to fall.

The father does not only warn. He points to a positive alternative: delight in the wife of your youth. "Let her breasts fill you at all times with delight; be intoxicated always in her love." The Bible is not suspicious of desire. It places it in marriage, where it is meant to flourish. The metaphor of the cistern and the fountain makes the point: there is a rightful source of satisfaction, and it is close to home. The ultimate reason is theological: "A man's ways are before the eyes of the LORD." Nothing is hidden.

Chapter 6 widens the lens. Be careful about taking on debt for others, and get out quickly if you are in. Look at the ant, which works without anyone forcing her. The sluggard sleeps and poverty comes "like a robber." Then the list of seven things the LORD hates, which includes haughty eyes, a lying tongue, hands that shed innocent blood, and "one who sows discord among brothers."

The chapter returns to adultery with a blunt statement: "He who commits adultery lacks sense; he who does it destroys himself." It describes the cost in plain terms. The commandment is "a lamp" and the teaching "a light," guiding the way through the dark.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus taught that sin begins in the heart and in the eyes (Matthew 5:27-30). Paul says to "flee from sexual immorality" (1 Corinthians 6:18), echoing "keep your way far from her." Hebrews 13:4 says marriage is to be held in honor. Ephesians 5:25-32 shows marriage as a picture of Christ and the church, a love that is faithful. Jesus is the faithful husband who never fails his bride.

STEP 6

Application

Identify one "door" you need to stay far from this week.

If you are married, thank God for your spouse. Do something to delight them.

Consider where laziness or debt are hurting your life, and take one step.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you far from the door of temptation.
- Ask him to give you delight in what he has given.
- Thank Jesus, the faithful bridegroom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 305 · WEEK 44

Psalm 19

The heavens and the law, creation and word declare God's glory

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 19. It is a psalm in two halves, one about God's glory in the heavens and one about his glory in his word. Notice how the psalmist connects them.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 19 is a psalm of David, and C. S. Lewis called it among the greatest poems in the Psalter. It moves from creation to Scripture to the heart. It stands at a fitting place in this unit: wisdom literature teaches that God's world and God's word fit together. Proverbs says that God made the world by wisdom, and this psalm shows how the world and the law both tell of him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork" (v. 1).
2. "Day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge" (v. 2).
3. "There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard" (v. 3).
4. "In them he has set a tent for the sun" (v. 4).
5. "The law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul; the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple" (v. 7).
6. "More to be desired are they than gold, even much fine gold; sweeter also than honey and drippings of the honeycomb" (v. 10).
7. "Who can discern his errors? Declare me innocent from hidden faults" (v. 12).

8 “Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable in your sight, O LORD, my rock and my redeemer” (v. 14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first half is a hymn to the silent voice of creation. The sky speaks without words, and its message goes out to all the earth. The sun is described as a bridegroom coming out of his chamber, running its course with joy. Creation is a constant witness. It tells us that there is a God, that he is glorious, and that he is powerful. Paul uses this psalm to say that no one is without a witness (Romans 10:18).

But creation’s testimony, however clear, is limited. It tells of God’s glory, but it does not tell us how to know him or be forgiven. So the psalm turns, in verse 7, to the law of the LORD. Six names for God’s word, six descriptions, and six effects fill the second section. The law is perfect, reviving the soul. The testimony is sure, making wise the simple. The precepts are right, rejoicing the heart. The commandment is pure, enlightening the eyes. The fear of the LORD is clean, enduring forever. The rules are true and righteous. God’s word does what the heavens cannot: it restores, it instructs, it gives joy.

The word is also better than wealth and sweeter than honey. The psalmist treasures it. But it also warns: “By them is your servant warned; in keeping them there is great reward.”

The third section is personal. Having seen God’s glory in the heavens and the word, the psalmist sees himself. He realizes that he cannot see his own faults. “Who can discern his errors?” He asks for cleansing from hidden sins and for restraint from presumptuous ones. And the psalm ends with the most beloved prayer: “Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable in your sight, O LORD, my rock and my redeemer.”

The movement is from creation, to Scripture, to the heart. The glory of God, rightly seen, makes us aware of our need for him.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 1:19-20 and 10:18 draw on this psalm’s picture of creation’s witness. Hebrews 1:1-2 says God has spoken by his Son. John 1:14 shows the Word made flesh, who is the fullest revelation of God’s glory. Jesus said, “The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life” (John 6:63). The “redeemer” of the last verse is fulfilled in Christ (Titus 2:14).

STEP 6

Application

Step outside today and let the sky speak. Thank God for what you see.

Read verses 7 to 9 slowly. Pick the description of God's word that you most need right now.

Pray verse 14 as you start your day.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for speaking through both creation and his word.
- Ask him to cleanse you from hidden faults and keep you from presumption.
- Pray Psalm 19:14 as your own prayer.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 306 · WEEK 44

Psalm 119:1-40

Blessed are those whose way is blameless

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 40 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:1-40. This is the first of several readings from the longest chapter in the Bible, a poem in praise of God's word. Notice how many different words for Scripture the psalmist uses.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 119 is an acrostic of twenty-two stanzas, each of eight verses, with each verse in a stanza beginning with the same Hebrew letter. Nearly every verse mentions God's word under one of several names: law, testimonies, precepts, statutes, commandments, rules, word, and promise. The author is unnamed. Over the next weeks you will read it in sections, alongside Proverbs. The first stanzas describe the blessing of walking in God's word and the psalmist's longing to keep it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed are those whose way is blameless, who walk in the law of the LORD!" (v. 1).
2. "With my whole heart I seek you; let me not wander from your commandments!" (v. 10).
3. "How can a young man keep his way pure? By guarding it according to your word" (v. 9).
4. "I have stored up your word in my heart, that I might not sin against you" (v. 11).
5. "Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law" (v. 18).
6. "I am a sojourner on the earth; hide not your commandments from me!" (v. 19).
7. "Turn my eyes from looking at worthless things; and give me life in your ways" (v. 37).
8. "I will run in the way of your commandments when you enlarge my heart!" (v. 32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins as Psalm 1 does, with the word “blessed.” The blessed person walks in the law of the LORD. The psalmist is not claiming to have achieved it. His prayer is that he would. He asks God to teach him, to keep him from wandering, and to open his eyes.

Verse 9 asks the question every young person faces: “How can a young man keep his way pure?” The answer is simple and demanding: guard it according to God’s word. The word is not a decoration. It is a guardrail. And verse 11 shows how: “I have stored up your word in my heart.” Memorizing and treasuring Scripture is a defense against sin. The word has to be inside to act as a guard.

Verse 18 is one of the best prayers for anyone who opens a Bible: “Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law.” The psalmist knows that reading is not enough. The Spirit must open our eyes. Even a faithful reader needs God’s help to see what is there.

There is an honest strain in these verses. The psalmist feels like a sojourner, a foreigner, in the world. He asks God not to hide his commandments. He feels the pull of what is worthless, so he prays for God to turn his eyes. He knows that obedience does not come naturally.

Verse 32 offers a lovely picture: “I will run in the way of your commandments when you enlarge my heart.” Obedience is not a grim trudge. When God widens the heart, it becomes a run. The psalm is not a manual of rule-keeping. It is the song of someone who has fallen in love with the voice of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the Word made flesh, and he is the one who perfectly walked in the law of the LORD (John 1:14; Matthew 5:17). He said, “Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God” (Matthew 4:4). Ephesians 1:18 prays that “the eyes of your hearts [be] enlightened,” echoing verse 18. Colossians 3:16 urges, “Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly.”

STEP 6

Application

Choose one verse to store up in your heart this week, as verse 11 urges.

Pray verse 18 before you read the Bible tomorrow.

Ask what “worthless things” your eyes are drawn to, and bring that to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you want to seek him with your whole heart.
- Ask him to store his word in your heart so that you do not sin.
- Ask him to open your eyes to wonderful things in it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 307 · WEEK 44

Proverbs 7:1-8:36

The seductress; Wisdom personified, the craftsman at God's side

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 63 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 7:1-8:36. Chapter 7 is a vivid warning about a seductive woman, and chapter 8 is one of the great poems of the Bible, in which Wisdom herself speaks. Read chapter 8 slowly. It is the high point of the first nine chapters.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These two chapters set the opposite voices in sharp contrast. In chapter 7, a young man without sense is drawn to a smooth-talking woman. In chapter 8, Wisdom speaks, calling to all who will listen. She reveals that she is older than creation and was with God as he made the world. This is among the passages most important for how the church has understood the relationship between wisdom and Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Bind them on your fingers; write them on the tablet of your heart" (7:3).
2. "And behold, the woman meets him, dressed as a prostitute, wily of heart" (7:10).
3. "All at once he follows her, as an ox goes to the slaughter" (7:22).
4. "Her house is the way to Sheol, going down to the chambers of death" (7:27).
5. "Does not wisdom call? Does not understanding raise her voice?" (8:1).
6. "The fear of the LORD is hatred of evil" (8:13).
7. "The LORD possessed me at the beginning of his work, the first of his acts of old" (8:22).
8. "Then I was beside him, like a master workman, and I was daily his delight, rejoicing before him always" (8:30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 7 tells the story like a short film. A young man with no sense walks along the street at twilight, near the corner of her house. A woman meets him with flattery, religious language ("I had to offer sacrifices"), and an invitation. He follows "as an ox goes to the slaughter." The chapter describes the way sin deceives: it comes with smooth talk, a good reason, and a sense of safety. And the end is death.

The warning is not simply a moral rule. It is meant to help the reader see what he is walking into. The young man's problem was lack of sense, but also lack of caution. He was in the wrong place at the wrong time. "Do not let your heart turn aside to her ways."

Then Wisdom speaks. She calls from the heights, at the crossroads, and at the gates. Unlike the seductress, she calls openly. She offers "noble things," truth, and righteousness. Her fruit is better than gold. Kings reign by her. And she says, "Those who love me I love, and those who seek me diligently find me."

The center of chapter 8 is verses 22 to 31. Wisdom says that the LORD possessed her at the beginning, before the earth. She was there when he set the heavens in place and marked out the foundations of the earth. "I was beside him, like a master workman." Wisdom is not a mere abstraction. She is portrayed as a person, present with God and delighting in him, and in the human race. Christians have long read this passage in the light of the New Testament as a shadow of Christ, though it should be read carefully. In its own setting, Wisdom is a poetic personification of God's wisdom. In the light of the whole Bible, it points to the Son through whom the world was made.

The chapter ends with a stark choice: "Whoever finds me finds life… but he who fails to find me injures himself; all who hate me love death."

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:1-3 says that the Word was with God in the beginning, and all things were made through him. Colossians 1:15-17 says Christ is "the firstborn of all creation" and that all things were created through him. 1 Corinthians 1:24 calls Christ "the power of God and the wisdom of God." Jesus said, "Come to me, all who labor" (Matthew 11:28), the call of Wisdom in the form of a Savior.

STEP 6

Application

Notice what voices speak to you with smooth words today. Do they lead to life?

Read 8:22-31 aloud as praise to Christ, the one through whom all things were made.

Ask God to help you hate evil, as verse 13 describes.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from ways that lead to death.
- Thank him for Wisdom who calls aloud.
- Thank Christ, who was with the Father in the beginning.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 308 · WEEK 44

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Proverbs 1:7 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

REST

Meditation

This verse is the motto of the whole book of Proverbs, and it appears again in 9:10. Everything in the book rests on it.

"The fear of the LORD." The word fear has two layers in the Bible. There is the awe that shakes us when we realize who God is, and there is the trust that keeps us coming to him. A child who loves and respects his father fears him in this sense: he takes him seriously and does not want to displease him. To fear the LORD is to live as though God is real, holy, good, and in charge.

"Is the beginning." The word can mean either the first part or the chief part. Both are true. It is where wisdom starts, and it is what wisdom is made of. You cannot skip it and arrive at wisdom some other way.

“Of knowledge.” It is the starting point for knowing anything rightly. The world makes sense only if the one who made it is acknowledged. Apart from him, knowledge becomes fragmented, proud, or useless.

“Fools despise wisdom and instruction.” The fool is not one who lacks intelligence but one who rejects correction. He thinks he knows best. The contrast is between a person who bows to God and a person who bows to himself.

For the Christian, the fear of the LORD is not opposed to the love of God. It deepens as we see his holiness and his grace together at the cross. We fear him because he is holy, and we run to him because he is merciful. Pray this verse often, and ask God to give you a heart that fears him.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the wisdom books. You opened Proverbs and heard the father’s call to his son, with the fear of the LORD as the starting point. You read the anchor of the unit, Proverbs 3:5-6, which calls us to trust the LORD with all our heart and not to lean on our own understanding. You read the warnings about adultery, debt, and laziness, and the beautiful alternative of faithful love. In the Psalms you saw the glory of God in creation and in his word in Psalm 19, and began Psalm 119 with its longing to walk in God’s law. You ended the week with Wisdom’s own speech in Proverbs 8, where she stands beside God at creation. The week taught that wisdom starts with reverent trust in God, that his word guards the heart, and that Christ is the wisdom of God.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Proverbs 3:5-6 asks us to trust the LORD with all our heart and not lean on our own understanding. Where are you leaning on your own understanding right now?

Proverbs 8 pictures Wisdom as present with God at creation, and the New Testament shows Christ as the wisdom of God. How does that change the way you think about seeking wisdom?

Psalm 119:11 says, “I have stored up your word in my heart, that I might not sin against you.” What is one practical way you can store up God’s word this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to begin knowing him with fear.

Thank him for Christ, the wisdom of God.

Rest, and ask him to guard your way with his word.

DAY 309 · WEEK 45

Proverbs 9:1-11:31

Wisdom and Folly's rival invitations

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 9:1-11:31. Chapter 9 closes the first major section with two rival invitations. Chapters 10 and 11 begin the collection of short sayings. Notice the change of style.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 9 ends the long introduction with a banquet scene. Lady Wisdom and the woman Folly both call out from the heights of the city, but one leads to life and the other to the grave. Then, beginning at chapter 10, the book changes. The long speeches give way to short two-line sayings, mostly about the contrast between the righteous and the wicked. These are the proverbs most people think of.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Wisdom has built her house; she has hewn her seven pillars" (9:1).
2. "Leave your simple ways, and live, and walk in the way of insight" (9:6).
3. "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom, and the knowledge of the Holy One is insight" (9:10).
4. "The woman Folly is loud; she is seductive and knows nothing" (9:13).
5. "But he does not know that the dead are there, that her guests are in the depths of Sheol" (9:18).
6. "A wise son makes a glad father, but a foolish son is a sorrow to his mother" (10:1).
7. "When pride comes, then comes disgrace, but with the humble is wisdom" (11:2).

8 “Whoever brings blessing will be enriched, and one who waters will himself be watered” (11:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The picture in chapter 9 is of two banquets. Wisdom has built her house, prepared her meat, mixed her wine, and sent out her servants. The invitation is open to the simple. Folly also sits at the door of her house, on the high places of the city, calling to those passing by. The words are similar, but the end is different. “He does not know that the dead are there.” The meal that looks like life is the doorway to death.

The chapter’s lesson is that no one is neutral. Everyone is eating at one of the two tables. We are being formed either by wisdom or by folly. And verse 10 repeats the theme: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom.”

Chapter 10 begins the first collection of sayings attributed to Solomon. They are scattered, not organized by topic, and the reader is meant to take them one at a time, like a string of pearls. Many are contrasts: the righteous and the wicked, the diligent and the lazy, the wise and the fool.

It is important to read proverbs as proverbs. They are general truths about how the world tends to work, not promises that apply in every case. “The hand of the diligent will rule” is generally true. It is not a guarantee. Proverbs describe the grain of the world, the way things usually go when God’s moral order is at work. The book of Job and Ecclesiastes will later explore the exceptions.

Several themes emerge in these chapters: honest speech, generosity, humility, and the danger of pride. “Whoever is generous will be blessed.” “One gives freely, yet grows all the richer.” Generosity is not a loss but a form of wisdom. The righteous are described as a tree of life, a “fruit” that helps others. And “whoever trusts in his riches will fall, but the righteous will flourish like a green leaf.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told parables of two houses (Matthew 7:24-27) and two banquets (Luke 14:15-24), and spoke of the narrow and wide gates (Matthew 7:13-14). He is the true wisdom who sends out his servants with the invitation to come to the feast (Matthew 22:1-10). He said, “It is more blessed to give than to receive” (Acts 20:35), echoing 11:25. Proverbs 11:30 (“the fruit of the righteous is a tree of life”) points to Revelation 22:2.

STEP 6

Application

Ask which table you are eating at today. What is feeding you: wisdom or folly?

Practice one act of generosity this week and watch what it does to your heart.

Read proverbs one at a time, and slowly. Choose one to think about throughout the day.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Accept Wisdom's invitation, and tell God what that means for you.

Ask him to keep you from the table of Folly.

Thank Christ for spreading a feast for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."

PSALM 119:105

DAY 310 · WEEK 45

Proverbs 12:1-14:35

The fruit of the lips; diligence; the way of the upright

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 12:1-14:35. These chapters continue the collection of contrasting sayings. As you read, look for what the proverbs say about the tongue, hard work, and the way that seems right.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters continue the first Solomonic collection. The sayings are brief, and they move quickly from subject to subject. They are not meant to be read all at once but to be pondered. Look for repeated themes: speech, work, the fear of the LORD, and the difference between appearance and reality. Some of the most quoted proverbs appear here.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Whoever loves discipline loves knowledge, but he who hates reproof is stupid” (12:1).
2. “There is one whose rash words are like sword thrusts, but the tongue of the wise brings healing” (12:18).
3. “Anxiety in a man’s heart weighs him down, but a good word makes him glad” (12:25).
4. “The soul of the sluggard craves and gets nothing, while the soul of the diligent is richly supplied” (13:4).
5. “Whoever walks with the wise becomes wise, but the companion of fools will suffer harm” (13:20).
6. “Whoever spares the rod hates his son, but he who loves him is diligent to discipline him” (13:24).
7. “There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way to death” (14:12).

8 “Righteousness exalts a nation, but sin is a reproach to any people” (14:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sayings of these chapters circle around a few basic truths. First, the willingness to be corrected is the mark of the wise. “Whoever loves discipline loves knowledge.” The person who hates correction is called “stupid,” a strong word. It is a challenge to anyone who is touchy about criticism. Growth requires being willing to be told when we are wrong.

Second, words matter. Rash words are like swords, but wise words heal. The tongue can wound or it can restore. “A good word makes him glad.” A kind word to an anxious person is a gift. The book returns again and again to speech, because speech reveals and shapes the heart.

Third, the company we keep forms us. “Whoever walks with the wise becomes wise.” We become like those we spend time with. The proverb is a reminder to choose friendships carefully, and to be the kind of friend others can learn from.

The most searching proverb in the section is 14:12: “There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way to death.” It appears twice in the book (16:25). The danger is not only that we choose obvious wrong. It is that we are often convinced we are right. Self-deception is a serious problem, and it is why we need God’s word and wise counsel. We cannot trust our own sense of rightness.

The collection also includes strong statements on work, honesty, and the poor. “Whoever oppresses a poor man insults his Maker, but he who is generous to the needy honors him.” How we treat the poor is a statement about how we regard God. And there are sayings about the fear of the LORD as a fountain of life and a place of confidence.

The section ends with a corporate lesson: “Righteousness exalts a nation.” Moral character is not a private matter. It shapes whole societies.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that out of the abundance of the heart the mouth speaks (Matthew 12:34), and that we will give an account for every careless word (Matthew 12:36). He warned that many call the narrow way hard and choose the broad one (Matthew 7:13-14). Proverbs 14:31 is echoed in Matthew 25:40: “As you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me.” James 3 expands on the power of the tongue.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a recent conversation. Did your words wound or heal? Ask forgiveness if needed.

Examine your friendships. Who are you becoming like?

Ask God where you might have a “way that seems right” that leads somewhere else.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you a love for correction.
- Ask him to make your words bring healing.
- Ask him to show you the way that seems right but is not.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

“Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path.”

PSALM 119:105

DAY 311 · WEEK 45

Psalm 119:41-96

Steadfast love and the commandments

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:41-96. Today's section moves from steadfast love to affliction. Notice how the psalmist finds comfort in God's word in suffering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second reading from Psalm 119, covering stanzas four through eleven. The psalmist is under pressure. Insolent people mock him, and he suffers affliction. Yet again and again, he turns to the word of God, which he finds to be his comfort, his song, and his life. The section includes some of the most famous lines of the whole psalm.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Let your steadfast love come to me, O LORD, your salvation according to your promise" (v. 41).
2. "And I shall walk in a wide place, for I have sought your precepts" (v. 45).
3. "This is my comfort in my affliction, that your promise gives me life" (v. 50).
4. "Your statutes have been my songs in the house of my sojourning" (v. 54).
5. "The LORD is my portion; I promise to keep your words" (v. 57).
6. "It is good for me that I was afflicted, that I might learn your statutes" (v. 71).
7. "Forever, O LORD, your word is firmly fixed in the heavens" (v. 89).
8. "If your law had not been my delight, I would have perished in my affliction" (v. 92).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Verse 41 begins with a request for God's steadfast love. The psalmist asks that God's covenant love come to him, according to his promise. The word of God and the love of God are tied together. The promise is the way God's love reaches us.

The theme of affliction threads through the section. The psalmist does not say that God's word makes life painless. He says that it is his comfort in affliction. "Your promise gives me life." The promise is what keeps him alive when everything else is hard. A believer in difficult times needs something to hold, and God's word is it. The psalmist even makes songs from the statutes "in the house of my sojourning." He sings the word in a foreign place.

The most challenging line is verse 71: "It is good for me that I was afflicted, that I might learn your statutes." It is a statement made in hindsight. The writer does not say that suffering is pleasant. He says that it taught him. Affliction drove him to God's word and made him learn what comfort cannot. And verse 67: "Before I was afflicted I went astray, but now I keep your word." Trouble corrected him.

The psalm also says the LORD is his portion, as the Levites had no land but God himself as their inheritance. For the psalmist, owning God is greater than owning anything else.

Verse 89 stands as a statement of confidence: "Forever, O LORD, your word is firmly fixed in the heavens." Human opinions shift. Cultures change. God's word does not. His faithfulness continues to all generations, and the earth established by him endures. And verse 92 is a stark acknowledgment: "If your law had not been my delight, I would have perished."

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away" (Matthew 24:35). Romans 8:28 says God works all things for good for those who love him, echoing verse 71. Hebrews 12:11 speaks of the peaceful fruit of discipline. 2 Corinthians 1:3-5 describes God as the Father of mercies and God of all comfort. Peter writes that the word of the Lord remains forever (1 Peter 1:25).

STEP 6

Application

If you are in affliction, name one promise from Scripture to hold on to this week.

Look back at a hardship and ask what God taught you through it.

Sing or read aloud a verse of Scripture in a hard place, as the psalmist did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask for God’s steadfast love according to his promise.
- Tell him where his promise gives you life in affliction.
- Ask him to fix his word in your heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

“Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path.”

PSALM 119:105

DAY 312 · WEEK 45

Proverbs 15:1-17:28

The gentle answer; God weighs the heart; friendship

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 15:1-17:28. As you read, look for what these chapters teach about words, the heart, and the sovereignty of God over human plans.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters continue the Solomonic collection, and now more sayings speak directly about the LORD. They deal with the gentle answer, the way God sees the heart, plans and God's purposes, pride, and friendship. Chapter 16 in particular grapples with how human planning and divine control fit together.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "A soft answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger" (15:1).
2. "The eyes of the LORD are in every place, keeping watch on the evil and the good" (15:3).
3. "Without counsel plans fail, but with many advisers they succeed" (15:22).
4. "All the ways of a man are pure in his own eyes, but the LORD weighs the spirit" (16:2).
5. "Commit your work to the LORD, and your plans will be established" (16:3).
6. "The heart of man plans his way, but the LORD establishes his steps" (16:9).
7. "Pride goes before destruction, and a haughty spirit before a fall" (16:18).
8. "A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for adversity" (17:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The famous opening line of chapter 15 gives a practical truth: “A soft answer turns away wrath.” A gentle word can defuse a conflict. The next lines contrast the wise tongue with the foolish mouth, and show that the way we speak reflects the state of our hearts. The whole section turns often to the tongue: “A gentle tongue is a tree of life, but perverseness in it breaks the spirit.”

Verse 3 says that “the eyes of the LORD are in every place.” It can be a comfort or a warning. For the one who hides, it is a warning. For the one who walks in integrity, it is a comfort. God sees. We are not unobserved, and we are not forgotten.

Chapter 16 sets a key principle of Christian life: our planning and God’s sovereignty. “The heart of man plans his way, but the LORD establishes his steps.” We should make plans. The Bible does not say planning is wrong. But we hold them with open hands. God has the final say. “The lot is cast into the lap, but its every decision is from the LORD.” Even what looks like chance is under his rule. This does not make us passive. It makes us humble and trusting. “Commit your work to the LORD, and your plans will be established.”

Verse 2 is a warning about self-assessment: “All the ways of a man are pure in his own eyes, but the LORD weighs the spirit.” We tend to judge ourselves by our intentions and others by their actions. God weighs the heart. And the famous verse 18 warns about pride, “before a fall.” The humble in spirit, by contrast, are described as better off than the proud.

Chapter 17 includes a series of sayings about friendship and family: “A friend loves at all times.” “A joyful heart is good medicine, but a crushed spirit dries up the bones.” And it also warns about quarreling. “The beginning of strife is like letting out water, so quit before the quarrel breaks out.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus, “when he was reviled, did not revile in return” (1 Peter 2:23), and taught that blessed are the meek (Matthew 5:5). Paul wrote, “Let your speech always be gracious” (Colossians 4:6). James 4:13-15 echoes Proverbs 16:9: “You ought to say, If the Lord wills, we will live.” Jesus, the friend of sinners (Luke 7:34), is “a friend who sticks closer than a brother.” Romans 8:28 holds God’s sovereignty and our good together.

STEP 6

Application

In your next tense conversation, try a soft answer.

Hold one of your plans loosely today. Commit it to the LORD, and notice what changes.

Consider where you judge yourself by your intentions, and ask God to weigh your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you gentle answers.
- Ask him to establish your steps and keep you from pride.
- Thank him that he weighs the spirit with perfect knowledge.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

“Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path.”

PSALM 119:105

DAY 313 · WEEK 45

Proverbs 18:1-19:29

The tongue; pride; plans and the LORD's purposes

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 18:1-19:29. Notice the sayings about the power of the tongue, the LORD as a refuge, and how God's purposes stand above human plans.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapters 18 and 19 continue to gather sayings on speech, friendship, wealth and poverty, and discipline. Some of the best loved lines in the book are here, including the strong tower and the friend who sticks closer than a brother. The sayings are loosely organized but return to central themes of the book.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "If one gives an answer before he hears, it is his folly and shame" (18:13).
2. "The name of the LORD is a strong tower; the righteous man runs into it and is safe" (18:10).
3. "The rich man's wealth is his strong city, and like a high wall in his imagination" (18:11).
4. "Death and life are in the power of the tongue, and those who love it will eat its fruits" (18:21).
5. "He who finds a wife finds a good thing and obtains favor from the LORD" (18:22).
6. "A man of many companions may come to ruin, but there is a friend who sticks closer than a brother" (18:24).
7. "Whoever is generous to the poor lends to the LORD, and he will repay him for his deed" (19:17).

8 “Many are the plans in the mind of a man, but it is the purpose of the LORD that will stand” (19:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Two strongholds are set side by side in chapter 18. The name of the LORD is a strong tower, and the rich man’s wealth is a strong city “in his imagination.” The comparison is sharp. The rich man imagines himself secure, but his wall is only in his mind. The righteous man runs to the LORD and is actually safe. We all have something we run to when life is threatening: money, a plan, a person, a reputation. Proverbs asks whether that thing is a real tower or an imagined one.

The proverbs on speech continue. “If one gives an answer before he hears, it is his folly.” Listening before speaking is a mark of wisdom. “Death and life are in the power of the tongue.” The tongue is a powerful instrument. The one who uses it will taste the results, good or bad.

A significant saying about friendship appears at the end of chapter 18. “A man of many companions may come to ruin, but there is a friend who sticks closer than a brother.” Quantity is not the measure of friendship. A single faithful friend is worth more than a crowd. Believers have always seen in this verse a picture of Christ.

Chapter 19 contains a strong statement on caring for the poor: “Whoever is generous to the poor lends to the LORD, and he will repay him.” Generosity to the poor is loaning to God himself. He takes it personally. It is one of the Bible’s most striking ideas: the poor man is God’s debtor, and God promises to repay.

The key theological statement of the chapter is verse 21: “Many are the plans in the mind of a man, but it is the purpose of the LORD that will stand.” We make many plans. Some come to nothing. But God’s purpose cannot be overturned. This is a comfort to those who trust him, and a warning to those who plot against him. And verse 23: “The fear of the LORD leads to life, and whoever has it rests satisfied.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the friend who sticks closer than a brother. He said, “No longer do I call you servants… but I have called you friends” (John 15:15). He is the strong tower, the refuge of the weary (Hebrews 6:18). Matthew 25:40 shows that kindness to the least is kindness to Christ. In Acts 4:28 the plans of men against Jesus served only “whatever your hand and your plan had predestined to take place.”

STEP 6

Application

Name your “strong tower.” Is it the LORD, or something imaginary?

Practice listening fully before answering in your next important conversation.

Give something to a person in need this week, and think of it as lending to the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Run into the strong tower of God’s name, and tell him why you need it.

Ask him to guard your tongue and teach you to listen.

Thank Jesus, the friend who sticks closer than a brother.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

“Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path.”

PSALM 119:105

DAY 314 · WEEK 45

Proverbs 20:1-21:31

Justice, integrity, and the king's heart in the LORD's hand

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 20:1-21:31. These chapters continue the collection. Notice what is said about the king, justice, and the heart, and the great statement in 21:1 and 21:31.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The sayings of chapters 20 and 21 have a strong focus on rulers, justice, and honest dealing. This is fitting for a collection associated with a king. They also continue the theme of God's rule over human hearts and plans. As the last of the Solomonic sayings before the "Sayings of the Wise," these chapters are a high point in the theology of providence.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Wine is a mocker, strong drink a brawler, and whoever is led astray by it is not wise" (20:1).
2. "Who can say, I have made my heart pure; I am clean from my sin?" (20:9).
3. "The hearing ear and the seeing eye, the LORD has made them both" (20:12).
4. "Do not say, I will repay evil; wait for the LORD, and he will deliver you" (20:22).
5. "The king's heart is a stream of water in the hand of the LORD; he turns it wherever he will" (21:1).
6. "Every way of a man is right in his own eyes, but the LORD weighs the heart" (21:2).
7. "To do righteousness and justice is more acceptable to the LORD than sacrifice" (21:3).
8. "The horse is made ready for the day of battle, but the victory belongs to the LORD" (21:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 20 begins with a warning about drink, then turns to honesty and the king's role. A king who sits on the throne of judgment "winnows all evil with his eyes." Good rule requires moral discernment. Yet the chapter also contains a question that humbles every ruler: "Who can say, I have made my heart pure; I am clean from my sin?" The answer is no one. Even the wisest king, and even the wisest reader, needs forgiveness.

Verse 22 is a gem for those who are wronged: "Do not say, I will repay evil; wait for the LORD, and he will deliver you." It echoes the principle of David's restraint with Saul. Vengeance belongs to God. Waiting is an act of faith. Honest scales and weights also come up repeatedly. "Unequal weights and unequal measures are both alike an abomination to the LORD." The God of the temple cares about the marketplace.

Chapter 21 opens with one of the most sweeping statements of God's sovereignty. "The king's heart is a stream of water in the hand of the LORD; he turns it wherever he will." The most powerful person in the land has a heart that is directed by God, as a farmer directs the channel of irrigation. God is not threatened by kings. He guides them, even when they do not know it. This is comfort for those living under unjust or foolish rulers.

Verse 3 repeats what Samuel told Saul and the prophets will say: "To do righteousness and justice is more acceptable to the LORD than sacrifice." Ritual without righteousness is empty. And verse 13 states a principle of mercy: "Whoever closes his ear to the cry of the poor will himself call out and not be answered."

The chapter ends with a verse that sums up providence: "The horse is made ready for the day of battle, but the victory belongs to the LORD." Prepare, plan, and work, but know that the result is God's. The following verse, 21:30, says, "No wisdom, no understanding, no counsel can avail against the LORD."

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that governing authorities are instituted by God (Romans 13:1), and 1 Timothy 2:1-2 urges prayer for kings. Jesus said, "My Father is working until now, and I am working" (John 5:17). Romans 12:19 echoes verse 22: "Never avenge yourselves... leave it to the wrath of God." Jesus quoted the prophets that God desires "mercy, and not sacrifice" (Matthew 9:13). Psalm 33:16-17 adds that a war horse is a false hope for victory.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for a leader whose decisions affect you, trusting that God can turn their heart.

When you are wronged, practice waiting on the LORD instead of repaying.

Do your part in a hard task, and release the outcome to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Admit before God that you cannot make your own heart pure.
- Ask him for mercy and for patience when you are wronged.
- Thank him that he holds even the king's heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."

PSALM 119:105

DAY 315 · WEEK 45

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 119:105 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."

PSALM 119:105

REST

Meditation

This is one of the best-loved verses about Scripture, from the middle of the longest chapter in the Bible. It uses a simple image: a lamp.

"Your word." The psalmist speaks to God, and says that the word is his. It is not the opinion of men. It is God's speech, and it has his authority and his love in it.

"Is a lamp to my feet." In the ancient world, a lamp was a small oil flame, held at the level of the feet. It did not light up the whole road. It showed the next few steps. This is how God's word usually works. We do not get a complete map of our future. We get enough light for the next step. And the psalmist does not complain about it. He is grateful for it. We walk by faith, one step at a time.

"And a light to my path." The path is the whole road of life, and the word shows where it leads. "Path" also suggests direction. The word of God not only lights each step but also reveals where it all goes, and warns of where the other paths end.

The verse invites us to treat the Bible not as a book of general ideas but as a daily guide. When you are unsure of a decision, the lamp is for your feet. When you are tempted, the lamp shows the pit. When you are afraid of the future, the lamp reminds you that the one who holds it knows the way.

For the Christian, this verse is fulfilled in Christ, who said, “I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life” (John 8:12). The word that lights our path has a name. Walk in his light.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you worked through the heart of Proverbs. You read the two banquets of Wisdom and Folly, and the first collection of Solomon’s sayings, with their contrasts between the righteous and the wicked. You saw how the gentle answer turns away wrath, how the tongue holds the power of life and death, and how the name of the LORD is a strong tower. You saw that human plans are held in God’s hand: the heart of man plans his way, but the LORD establishes his steps, and the king’s heart is a stream of water in his hand. In Psalm 119 you heard the psalmist turn to God’s word in affliction and say that it is good that he was afflicted. The week taught that wisdom is practical, that God is sovereign over human plans, and that his word is a light for each step.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Proverbs says that the name of the LORD is a strong tower, and that a rich man’s wealth is a strong city only in his imagination. What do you run to when you feel unsafe, and is it a real tower?

Jesus is the friend who sticks closer than a brother, and the one who held fast to the Father’s will. How does knowing his friendship change how you face a lonely or hard moment this week?

Psalm 119:105 says God’s word is a lamp to the feet. What is the next step you need light for, and how will you ask God for it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his word is a lamp for your feet.

Thank him for the strong tower of his name.

Rest, and ask him to establish your steps.

DAY 316 · WEEK 46

Proverbs 22:1-24:34

Sayings of the wise; warnings about wealth

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 68 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 22:1-24:34. A new section begins, the Sayings of the Wise. Read for what it says about reputation, wealth, and what to do when you fail.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

At 22:17 the collection changes. The father's voice returns, and the sayings are introduced as "the words of the wise." Many scholars see a link with ancient Egyptian wisdom texts, which shows that Israel's sages worked within the wider world of wisdom while rooting it in the fear of the LORD. These chapters give practical teaching on money, work, justice, and enemies.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "A good name is to be chosen rather than great riches, and favor is better than silver or gold" (22:1).
2. "The rich and the poor meet together; the LORD is the Maker of them all" (22:2).
3. "Train up a child in the way he should go; even when he is old he will not depart from it" (22:6).
4. "The rich rules over the poor, and the borrower is the slave of the lender" (22:7).
5. "Do not toil to acquire wealth; be discerning enough to desist" (23:4).
6. "Rescue those who are being taken away to death" (24:11).
7. "For the righteous falls seven times and rises again, but the wicked stumble in times of calamity" (24:16).

8 “Do not rejoice when your enemy falls, and let not your heart be glad when he stumbles” (24:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 22 opens with values. A good name, meaning a reputation for integrity, is worth more than wealth. And the rich and poor share the same Maker. No class is beyond God’s concern. The saying prepares for warnings elsewhere against exploiting the poor, “for the LORD will plead their cause.”

The well-known verse about training a child is a proverb, not a promise. It describes the general way that early formation shapes a life. It calls parents to teach deliberately, and it does not guarantee a result in every case. Proverbs elsewhere acknowledges that children can choose a different path. What the verse affirms is the power and the responsibility of early instruction.

Chapter 23 contains warnings about gluttony, drunkenness, and the pursuit of wealth. “Do not toil to acquire wealth.” Wealth is fragile: “When your eyes light on it, it is gone, for suddenly it sprouts wings.” The sayings on alcohol are vivid, describing its effects with humor and horror. The father also gives a tender instruction: “My son, give me your heart, and let your eyes observe my ways.” Wisdom is not just information but a relationship of trust.

Chapter 24 includes two of the book’s most challenging lines. Verse 11 calls us to rescue those being led to death. We cannot say, “Behold, we did not know this,” for God weighs the heart. Silence in the face of injustice is a failure. And verse 16 gives a glimpse of resilience: “The righteous falls seven times and rises again.” The righteous person is not one who never falls, but one who gets up. This gives comfort to anyone who has failed.

The warning about enemies is also bracing: “Do not rejoice when your enemy falls.” The reason is that the LORD will see it and be displeased. Gloating is a sin. And the chapter closes with a picture of the sluggard’s field, overgrown with thorns, and a warning that poverty comes “like a robber.” The wise man looks at the field and “receives instruction.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Let the children come to me” (Mark 10:14), and called for justice and mercy toward the least. Paul instructs fathers to bring children up “in the discipline and instruction of the Lord” (Ephesians 6:4). Jesus told the story of the Good Samaritan, who rescued the one being left for dead (Luke 10:30-37). The righteous who falls and rises again points to the One who rose, and to the grace that lifts his people (Micah 7:8).

STEP 6

Application

Ask what your reputation says about you, and whether it reflects your character.

Think about someone you could “rescue” this week: someone who needs an advocate.

If you have failed recently, hold on to 24:16. Get up.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you a good name before him.
- Ask him to help you rescue those being led toward death.
- Ask him to keep you from gloating over an enemy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

“Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised.”

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 317 · WEEK 46

Psalm 119:97-144

The commandments as wisdom

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:97-144. This section is the heart of the psalm. Notice how the psalmist describes the sweetness, the light, and the righteousness of God's word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the third reading from Psalm 119, covering stanzas thirteen through eighteen. It contains the famous verse 105, the lamp, and some of the strongest statements about how God's word gives wisdom. It fits the theme of the unit: the commandments as a source of insight and a guide for life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh how I love your law! It is my meditation all the day" (v. 97).
2. "Your commandment makes me wiser than my enemies, for it is ever with me" (v. 98).
3. "I have more understanding than all my teachers, for your testimonies are my meditation" (v. 99).
4. "How sweet are your words to my taste, sweeter than honey to my mouth!" (v. 103).
5. "Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path" (v. 105).
6. "The unfolding of your words gives light; it imparts understanding to the simple" (v. 130).
7. "My eyes shed streams of tears, because people do not keep your law" (v. 136).
8. "Your testimonies are righteous forever; give me understanding that I may live" (v. 144).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The stanza that begins at verse 97 starts with an exclamation: “Oh how I love your law!” The psalmist does not just obey. He loves. His meditation is constant, “all the day.” This is the Bible’s picture of a believer who treasures God’s word as a delight and a source of wisdom.

The claims of verses 98 to 100 are striking. The psalmist says he is wiser than his enemies, his teachers, and the aged. This is not arrogance but a statement about the power of the word. A humble student of Scripture may have more insight than a clever person who ignores it. Wisdom is not a matter of age or education. It is a matter of heeding God’s testimonies.

Verse 103 describes the word as sweet: “sweeter than honey.” It is both nourishing and delightful. And verse 105 gives the great image of the lamp. Verse 130 adds that “the unfolding of your words gives light.” The word brings understanding, especially to the simple. You do not need to be an expert. The unfolding, the opening up, of the word gives light.

The psalm is not naive. The section includes pain. In verse 136, the psalmist’s eyes shed streams of tears because others do not keep the law. Love for God’s word includes grief at its neglect. And in verses 107 and 139, he describes his affliction and his zeal consuming him. This is a person who feels deeply.

Verse 144 closes the passage with a request that sums up what the psalm is about: “Give me understanding that I may live.” Understanding and life belong together. To know God’s word is to live. The psalmist’s prayer is the same as ours: help me to see.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Man shall not live by bread alone” (Matthew 4:4), and “The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life” (John 6:63). He grieved over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41), echoing verse 136. Revelation 10:9-10 uses the image of the word as sweet as honey. Paul writes that the Scriptures “are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus” (2 Timothy 3:15).

STEP 6

Application

Read a short passage of Scripture today and ask: what is sweet in this?

Pray that you would grieve what grieves God.

Ask for understanding not just to know but to live.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you love about his law.
- Ask him for understanding that gives light.
- Grieve with him over those who do not keep his law.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

"Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised."

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 318 · WEEK 46

Proverbs 25:1-27:27

Hezekiah's collection; friendship; self-knowledge

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 25:1-27:27. A new collection begins, copied by the men of Hezekiah. As you read, notice the images from nature and everyday life, and what the sayings say about friends and enemies.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Proverbs 25:1 says that these are "also proverbs of Solomon which the men of Hezekiah king of Judah copied." They come from the time of Hezekiah, about 700 BC, when the scribes of Judah collected and preserved earlier wisdom. This collection is rich in similes and comparisons, drawn from the world of ordinary experience: snow, rain, apples, thorn bushes, iron.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It is the glory of God to conceal things, but the glory of kings is to search things out" (25:2).
2. "A word fitly spoken is like apples of gold in a setting of silver" (25:11).
3. "If your enemy is hungry, give him bread to eat, and if he is thirsty, give him water to drink" (25:21).
4. "Like a dog that returns to his vomit is a fool who repeats his folly" (26:11).
5. "Do not answer a fool according to his folly, lest you be like him yourself" (26:4), and "Answer a fool according to his folly, lest he be wise in his own eyes" (26:5).
6. "Do not boast about tomorrow, for you do not know what a day may bring" (27:1).
7. "Faithful are the wounds of a friend; profuse are the kisses of an enemy" (27:6).

8 “Iron sharpens iron, and one man sharpens another” (27:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The collection begins with a reflection on knowledge: “It is the glory of God to conceal things, but the glory of kings is to search things out.” God has left much to be discovered. The search for understanding is a kind of honor, and wisdom requires humility before the mystery of God.

The collection is full of word pictures. A word fitly spoken is like gold apples in a silver setting: beautiful, fitting, valuable. A faithful messenger is like cold snow in harvest time. A man without self-control is “like a city broken into and left without walls.” These images ask the reader to slow down and to see the world as a source of wisdom.

Chapter 25’s counsel about enemies is among the most radical in the Old Testament: “If your enemy is hungry, give him bread to eat.” Paul quotes it in Romans 12:20. To give food to an enemy is to overcome evil with good. The “burning coals” are probably a picture of shame leading to repentance.

Chapter 26 gathers the proverbs on fools in a stunning series. The seeming contradiction between 26:4 and 26:5 is intentional. Sometimes a fool should not be answered, so that you do not become like him. Sometimes he should be answered, so that he does not think himself wise. Wisdom is knowing which. Proverbs are not formulas. They require discernment.

Chapter 27 turns to friendship and self-knowledge. “Faithful are the wounds of a friend.” A true friend tells the truth, even when it hurts. “Iron sharpens iron.” We grow through honest relationships. And “as in water face reflects face, so the heart of man reflects the man.” The state of our heart shows in our life. The chapter ends with the call to know the condition of your flocks, a reminder that wealth does not last forever and that careful stewardship matters.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Proverbs 25:21-22 in Romans 12:20 and says, “Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good.” Jesus said, “Love your enemies” (Matthew 5:44), and showed it on the cross. James 4:13-14 echoes 27:1. Hebrews 10:24 calls believers to “stir up one another to love and good works.” Peter uses 26:11 in 2 Peter 2:22.

STEP 6

Application

Do something kind this week for someone who has been unkind to you.

Ask a trusted friend for honest feedback, and be ready to hear it as a wound that heals.

Think of a “word fitly spoken” that you could offer to someone today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to make you humble in your search for understanding.

Ask him to teach you to speak a word fitly spoken.

Ask him for the grace to receive the wounds of a friend.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

“Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised.”

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 319 · WEEK 46

Proverbs 28:1-29:27

Justice, leadership, and the righteous

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 28:1-29:27. These chapters are about leadership, justice, and the effect of rulers on a nation. Notice what they say about confession, and the fear of man.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters continue the collection copied by Hezekiah's men. The focus turns to rulers and the righteous. They reflect the concern for justice that runs through the prophets. The wise sayings here are strongly moral and contrast the righteous with the wicked, the oppressor with the generous, and the stubborn with the repentant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The wicked flee when no one pursues, but the righteous are bold as a lion" (28:1).
2. "Whoever conceals his transgressions will not prosper, but he who confesses and forsakes them will obtain mercy" (28:13).
3. "Blessed is the one who fears the LORD always, but whoever hardens his heart will fall into calamity" (28:14).
4. "Whoever trusts in his own mind is a fool, but he who walks in wisdom will be delivered" (28:26).
5. "Whoever gives to the poor will not want, but he who hides his eyes will get many a curse" (28:27).
6. "When the righteous increase, the people rejoice, but when the wicked rule, the people groan" (29:2).

7. “Where there is no prophecy the people cast off restraint, but blessed is he who keeps the law” (29:18).

8. “The fear of man lays a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is safe” (29:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first verse of chapter 28 describes a mark of conscience. The wicked run when no one is chasing them, because guilt is its own pursuer. The righteous are bold, because they have nothing to hide. A clear conscience is a source of courage.

Verse 13 is one of the central statements on confession in the Bible: “Whoever conceals his transgressions will not prosper, but he who confesses and forsakes them will obtain mercy.” Both confession and forsaking are required. It is not enough to admit a sin and carry on. And the promise is mercy. David knew this from his own experience (Psalm 32). Hiding sin makes things worse. Confessing opens the way to mercy.

Verse 26 returns to the theme of Proverbs 3:5. “Whoever trusts in his own mind is a fool.” The wise person knows the limits of his own judgment and relies on God. The proverbs about the poor continue: generosity brings blessing, while ignoring need brings a curse. And the book’s concern for rulers appears: “A ruler who lacks understanding is a cruel oppressor, but he who hates unjust gain will prolong his days.”

Chapter 29 gives an important principle for communities: “When the righteous increase, the people rejoice, but when the wicked rule, the people groan.” The character of leaders affects the lives of ordinary people. This is why believers pray for those in authority and take care in how they choose and serve.

Verse 18 is one of the most quoted: “Where there is no prophecy the people cast off restraint.” The Hebrew word for “prophecy” means vision or revelation. When God’s word is not heard, people lose their moorings. “But blessed is he who keeps the law.” And verse 25 states the central problem of the people-pleaser: “The fear of man lays a snare.” To fear people is to be trapped. To trust the LORD is to be safe.

STEP 5

Connection

1 John 1:9 says, “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us.” Jesus is the righteous bold as a lion, the Lion of the tribe of Judah (Revelation 5:5). Jesus said, “Do not fear those who kill the body” (Matthew 10:28). Paul says, “If I were still trying to please man, I would not be a servant of Christ” (Galatians 1:10). Amos 8:11 describes a famine of hearing the words of the LORD.

STEP 6

Application

Confess one thing you have been concealing, and turn from it.

Ask whose approval you fear most. Bring it to the LORD.

Pray for the leaders in your community, that righteousness would increase.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess and forsake a sin before God.
- Ask him to keep you from the fear of man.
- Ask him to make you bold because you are clean before him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

"Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised."

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 320 · WEEK 46

Proverbs 30:1-31:31

Agur's words; King Lemuel; the excellent wife

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 30:1-31:31. The book ends with the words of Agur, the words of King Lemuel, and the famous poem of the excellent wife. Read the final poem as the capstone of the book, and ask who she really is.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 30 is attributed to Agur, an otherwise unknown man, and includes numerical sayings and a prayer. Chapter 31 begins with what a queen mother taught her son the king, and ends with an acrostic poem in praise of "an excellent wife." It is the final word of Proverbs. Since the book opened with wisdom as a woman calling in the street, it closes with a portrait of wisdom lived out.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Surely I am more brutish than any man. I have not the understanding of a man" (30:2).
2. "Who has ascended to heaven and come down?... What is his name, and what is his son's name? Surely you know!" (30:4).
3. "Every word of God proves true; he is a shield to those who take refuge in him" (30:5).
4. "Give me neither poverty nor riches; feed me with the food that is needful for me" (30:8).
5. "Open your mouth for the mute, for the rights of all who are destitute" (31:8).
6. "An excellent wife who can find? She is far more precious than jewels" (31:10).
7. "Strength and dignity are her clothing, and she laughs at the time to come" (31:25).

8 “Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised” (31:30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Agur begins with a confession of humility, almost despairing. He claims no wisdom. He then asks rhetorical questions about who has ascended into heaven and gathered the wind in his fists, “What is his name, and what is his son’s name?” The questions point to the mystery of God. He knows his limits. And then comes a statement of faith: “Every word of God proves true; he is a shield to those who take refuge in him.” The proper response to our limits is not despair but trust in God’s word.

Agur’s prayer in verses 7 to 9 is a model of balanced petition. “Give me neither poverty nor riches.” He fears wealth, lest he deny God, and poverty, lest he steal. It shows self-knowledge. He asks for enough. The numerical sayings that follow, “Three things are too wonderful for me… four I do not understand,” show wonder at creation.

The words of King Lemuel are a mother’s teaching to her son. She warns against indulgence and calls him to speak up for those who have no voice. “Open your mouth for the mute.” A good ruler is an advocate for the helpless.

The final poem, the “excellent wife,” is an acrostic, each line beginning with the next letter of the Hebrew alphabet, a completeness from A to Z. She is a woman of strength, wisdom, industry, generosity, and fear of the LORD. She works with her hands, manages her household, trades, invests, gives to the poor, and teaches with kindness. The poem is not a checklist of tasks a woman must do. It is a portrait of wisdom embodied. The word “excellent” is the same word used elsewhere for a “mighty” warrior. It is a picture of valor.

The key line is verse 30: “Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised.” The book ends where it started: with the fear of the LORD. Wisdom is not an abstraction. It takes shape in a life lived under God.

STEP 5

Connection

Agur’s question, “Who has ascended to heaven and come down?” finds its answer in Christ (John 3:13; Ephesians 4:9-10). “Every word of God proves true” is echoed in Jesus’ trust in the Scriptures (Matthew 5:18). Ephesians 5:25-27 shows Christ’s love for the church as a bride. Jesus said, “Give us this day our daily bread” (Matthew 6:11), the prayer of Agur’s “food that is needful.”

STEP 6

Application

Pray Agur's prayer: ask God for "enough" and not too much or too little.

Whether man or woman, read the Proverbs 31 poem as a portrait of wisdom to imitate.

Speak up for someone who has no voice this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that every word of his proves true.

Ask him for neither poverty nor riches but what you need.

Ask him to teach you to open your mouth for those who cannot speak for themselves.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

"Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised."

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 321 · WEEK 46

Ecclesiastes 1:1-2:26

Vanity of vanities; the futility of wisdom and pleasure

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ecclesiastes 1:1-2:26. The tone changes sharply from Proverbs. Read slowly, and let the Preacher's honesty about life sink in. Do not rush to resolve it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ecclesiastes is the book of the Preacher (Hebrew Qoheleth), "the son of David, king in Jerusalem," traditionally taken to be Solomon. If Proverbs says that wisdom leads to life, Ecclesiastes asks what happens when life seems not to add up. The key word is "vanity," literally "breath" or "vapor." The Preacher explores life "under the sun," that is, as seen from a purely earthly viewpoint, and comes back with hard truths. This is the second book of the wisdom collection, and it is an honest companion to Proverbs.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Vanity of vanities, says the Preacher, vanity of vanities! All is vanity" (1:2).
2. "What does man gain by all the toil at which he toils under the sun?" (1:3).
3. "A generation goes, and a generation comes, but the earth remains forever" (1:4).
4. "What has been is what will be, and what has been done is what will be done, and there is nothing new under the sun" (1:9).
5. "For in much wisdom is much vexation, and he who increases knowledge increases sorrow" (1:18).
6. He tries pleasure, laughter, wine, great works, wealth, and music (2:1-8).
7. "Then I considered all that my hands had done… and behold, all was vanity and a striving after wind" (2:11).

8 “There is nothing better for a person than that he should eat and drink and find enjoyment in his toil. This also, I saw, is from the hand of God” (2:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first line stuns the reader: “Vanity of vanities! All is vanity.” The word “vanity” (hebel) means a breath, a vapor, something that cannot be grasped. The Preacher is not saying that life is meaningless in every way, but that it is fleeting and elusive, impossible to hold. His starting question is: what does a person gain from all his work? If all work ends in death and is forgotten, what is the point?

He observes nature: the sun rises and sets, the wind circles, the streams run to the sea, and nothing is ever finished. History repeats. There is “nothing new under the sun.” The human heart is not satisfied by seeing and hearing. These lines describe the weariness of life without a larger purpose.

In chapter 2, the Preacher conducts an experiment. He tries pleasure, laughter, wine. He builds houses and gardens, gathers silver and gold, and has everything his eyes desire. And at the end of it, “Behold, all was vanity and a striving after wind.” He does not deny that these things are enjoyable. He says they cannot satisfy. Wisdom is better than folly, as light is better than darkness, but the same fate comes to both. The wise man dies like the fool.

This is a painful honesty. The Preacher does not offer easy answers. He lays out the problem: a life lived only for what this world offers, even in the best circumstances, ends in frustration. Death is the great leveler.

But the chapter ends with a hint of something else: “There is nothing better than that he should eat and drink and find enjoyment in his toil. This also, I saw, is from the hand of God.” Enjoyment is possible, but only as a gift received from God, not as something grasped. This is the first note of a theme that runs through the book.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that creation was “subjected to futility” in hope of liberation (Romans 8:20-21), echoing the Preacher’s vanity. Jesus asked, “What does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?” (Mark 8:36). In Christ, our labor “is not in vain” (1 Corinthians 15:58). Jesus is the one who gives the satisfaction that nothing under the sun can: “Whoever drinks of the water that I will give him will never be thirsty” (John 4:14).

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you are chasing that cannot satisfy. Be honest.

Receive one ordinary joy today (a meal, a conversation) as a gift from God's hand.

Do not rush past the question of futility. Let it drive you to Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you tend to chase that leaves you empty.
- Ask him to satisfy you in himself.
- Ask him to teach you to receive eating, drinking, and work as gifts.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

"Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised."

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 322 · WEEK 46

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Proverbs 31:30 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised."

PROVERBS 31:30

REST

Meditation

This verse is the last great statement of the book of Proverbs. It sums up the portrait of the excellent wife, and it says what matters most.

"Charm is deceitful." Charm is the ability to win people with a pleasant manner. It can be real and it can be a cover. It can hide a hollow heart. We have all known people who were delightful and untrustworthy. Charm alone is not a foundation.

"And beauty is vain." The word "vain" is the same as "vanity" in Ecclesiastes: a breath that passes. Beauty fades. In a culture that prizes appearance, this verse says that it cannot bear the weight we put on it. This is not a criticism of beauty as such, which the Bible celebrates. It is a warning against making it the measure of a life.

“But a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised.” This is the heart of it. The thing that lasts is a heart that fears the LORD. The book that began with “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge” ends with the same note. Everything in the long poem of the excellent wife flows from this root. Her strength, her generosity, her wisdom, and her laughter at the days to come grow from it.

Although the verse speaks of a woman, the principle applies to every person. Whatever we are tempted to rely on, charm, looks, talent, or position, will fade. What endures is a life oriented toward God.

For the Christian, the fear of the LORD is fulfilled in a living faith in Christ, who calls us to a beauty that does not fade (1 Peter 3:3-4). Ask God to make this the thing you want to be known for.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished Proverbs and began Ecclesiastes. You read the Sayings of the Wise, with their call to rescue those being led to death and their promise that the righteous falls seven times and rises again. You read the collection copied by Hezekiah’s men, with the proverb that iron sharpens iron and the command to feed an enemy. You saw how confession brings mercy, how the fear of man is a snare, and how Agur prayed for neither poverty nor riches. You ended Proverbs with the excellent wife, the portrait of wisdom lived out. Then Ecclesiastes opened with its stark verdict: vanity of vanities. In Psalm 119 you read of the sweetness of God’s word and its power to give understanding. The week taught that wisdom is lived out in speech, friendship, justice, and generosity, and that nothing under the sun satisfies without God.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Proverbs 28:13 says, “Whoever conceals his transgressions will not prosper, but he who confesses and forsakes them will obtain mercy.” What do you need to bring into the light this week?

Proverbs 31 ends with the fear of the LORD as the root of a praiseworthy life, and Christ is the one who lived it perfectly. How does his life give you both a model and a Savior?

The Preacher says that everything under the sun is vanity. What is one thing you have been expecting to satisfy you that cannot?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to make the fear of him your root.

Tell him where you have trusted charm, beauty, or achievement.

Thank Christ for satisfying what nothing else can.

DAY 323 · WEEK 47

Ecclesiastes 3:1-4:16

A time for everything; oppression and friendship

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 38 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ecclesiastes 3:1-4:16. This includes the famous poem about time and the Preacher's reflections on oppression, envy, and companionship. Read the poem slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Preacher continues his reflection. Having seen that effort alone cannot satisfy, he now considers the structure of time itself. Chapter 3 is among the most quoted passages in the Bible, and chapter 4 returns to the harsh realities of oppression and loneliness, and offers a consolation in the value of friendship.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For everything there is a season, and a time for every matter under heaven" (3:1).
2. "A time to be born, and a time to die… a time to weep, and a time to laugh… a time to mourn, and a time to dance" (3:2-4).
3. "He has made everything beautiful in its time" (3:11).
4. "Also, he has put eternity into man's heart, yet so that he cannot find out what God has done from the beginning to the end" (3:11).
5. "I perceived that there is nothing better for them than to be joyful and to do good as long as they live" (3:12).
6. "I perceived that whatever God does endures forever" (3:14).
7. "And I saw all the oppressions that are done under the sun. And behold, the tears of the oppressed, and they had no one to comfort them" (4:1).
8. "Two are better than one, because they have a good reward for their toil" (4:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The poem of times is a catalog of fourteen pairs of opposite experiences: birth and death, planting and uprooting, weeping and laughing, embracing and refraining. It affirms that life has seasons, and that God governs them. It is not saying that all things are good, but that there is a time for everything, including grief. We are not meant to be always joyful or always sorrowful. Wisdom discerns the time.

The central statement is verse 11. God has made everything beautiful in its time. And he has put "eternity into man's heart." We have a sense of something beyond the present. We long for the permanent in a world of passing things. But we cannot see the whole picture. We live in the middle of the story and cannot grasp its end. This is why we are restless. The longing for eternity is a pointer to God. We are made for more than this world offers.

The Preacher's response is not despair but a call to receive life as a gift: be joyful, do good, eat and drink, and see it as the gift of God. And he reminds us of a comforting truth: "Whatever God does endures forever." Human works fade, but God's work stands. "God has done it, so that people fear before him."

Chapter 4 gives an honest view of injustice. The oppressed weep, and "they had no one to comfort them." The Preacher is moved by it, and he does not offer a quick answer. He sees envy driving much of human labor and sees the loneliness of those who work without end.

The balance comes in the section on companionship. "Two are better than one." If one falls, the other lifts him. Two keep warm. And the line, "A threefold cord is not quickly broken," has become a proverb for marriage and friendship. In a world of vapor, relationships are among the few things that give strength.

STEP 5

Connection

Galatians 4:4 says, "When the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son." The time of Christ's coming was God's chosen time. Jesus wept (John 11:35) and danced no less with joy (Luke 15:25-32), and entered all the seasons of human experience. Romans 8:18-25 describes our groaning as we wait. Jesus sent his disciples out two by two (Luke 10:1). Hebrews 10:24-25 urges believers not to neglect meeting together.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what season you are in. What is God asking of you in it?

Notice the "eternity" longing in your heart, and let it point you to God.

Think of a friend you can strengthen or lean on this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you discern the season you are in.
- Thank him for putting eternity in your heart.
- Pray for the oppressed, and ask what he would have you do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 324 · WEEK 47

Psalm 49

Why should I fear in times of trouble?, Ecclesiastes in the Psalter

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 49. This psalm is a wisdom psalm and a reflection on death and wealth. It is close to Ecclesiastes in tone. Read it as a sermon.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 49 is a psalm of the sons of Korah. It begins like a wisdom teacher's address to all peoples, rich and poor, and it takes up the same problem Ecclesiastes explores: all human beings die, whatever their wealth. It also gives an answer that Ecclesiastes only hints at: God will ransom the faithful from Sheol. It is placed here as the Psalter's echo of the Preacher.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hear this, all peoples! Give ear, all inhabitants of the world, both low and high, rich and poor together!" (vv. 1-2).
2. "My mouth shall speak wisdom; the meditation of my heart shall be understanding" (v. 3).
3. "Why should I fear in the days of evil, when the iniquity of my persecutors surrounds me?" (v. 5).
4. "Truly no man can ransom another, or give to God the price of his life" (v. 7).
5. "Man in his pomp will not remain; he is like the beasts that perish" (v. 12).
6. "Like sheep they are appointed for Sheol; Death shall be their shepherd" (v. 14).
7. "But God will ransom my soul from the power of Sheol, for he will receive me" (v. 15).
8. "Be not afraid when a man becomes rich, when the glory of his house increases. For when he dies he will carry nothing away" (vv. 16-17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a universal audience. It is not for Israel only but for all the inhabitants of the world. The question it addresses concerns everyone: why fear when the wealthy and powerful seem to have the upper hand? The answer is death. “No man can ransom another.” Not even the richest can buy his way out of the grave. “For he sees that even the wise die.” Wealth, wisdom, and fame all end in the same place.

The psalm describes the false confidence of the wealthy. They name lands after themselves. They trust in their riches and boast of their abundance. But “man in his pomp will not remain.” He is like the beasts. The psalm uses a shocking image: death is their shepherd, leading them like sheep to Sheol. They are being herded, not leading.

Then comes the great turn in verse 15. “But God will ransom my soul from the power of Sheol, for he will receive me.” It is one of the clearest statements of hope beyond death in the Old Testament. The word “ransom” recalls the failure of human ransom in verse 7. No man can ransom another, but God can. And “he will receive me” uses the same verb that was used of Enoch and Elijah being taken by God. It points to a hope of life with God beyond the grave.

The psalm ends with a call not to fear. Do not be afraid when the wicked prosper. They will leave everything behind. Their glory does not follow them. The wise person is not envious of what will be taken away.

This psalm answers the problem of vanity with the hope of ransom. It sees death clearly, but it does not end there.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “The Son of Man came… to give his life as a ransom for many” (Mark 10:45), the ransom no one else could pay. Paul says, “We brought nothing into the world, and we cannot take anything out of it” (1 Timothy 6:7). Hosea 13:14 and 1 Corinthians 15:54-57 speak of victory over Sheol. Jesus told the story of the rich fool (Luke 12:16-21), and said, “What will a man give in return for his soul?” (Mark 8:37).

STEP 6

Application

Do not envy someone who is wealthy. Ask what they will carry with them.

Thank Jesus for being the ransom that no man could pay.

Hold your possessions loosely, knowing that God will receive you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for giving his life as a ransom for you.

Tell God what you tend to trust in besides him, such as wealth or reputation.

Ask him to loosen your fear of death.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 325 · WEEK 47

Psalm 73

Truly God is good, Asaph almost slips; then sees the end

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 73. It is the story of a believer who almost lost his faith when he saw the wicked prosper. Notice the turning point in verses 16 and 17.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 73 opens Book III of the Psalter and is attributed to Asaph, a Levite who led worship in David's time. It deals with the problem Job and Ecclesiastes raise: why do the wicked prosper while the righteous suffer? The psalmist tells his own story of almost slipping. It is placed here as the Psalter's best answer to the Preacher's puzzles.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Truly God is good to Israel, to those who are pure in heart" (v. 1).
2. "But as for me, my feet had almost stumbled, my steps had nearly slipped" (v. 2).
3. "For I was envious of the arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the wicked" (v. 3).
4. "All in vain have I kept my heart clean and washed my hands in innocence" (v. 13).
5. "But when I thought how to understand this, it seemed to me a wearisome task, until I went into the sanctuary of God; then I discerned their end" (vv. 16-17).
6. "I was brutish and ignorant; I was like a beast toward you" (v. 22).
7. "Nevertheless, I am continually with you; you hold my right hand. You guide me with your counsel, and afterward you will receive me to glory" (vv. 23-24).
8. "Whom have I in heaven but you? And there is nothing on earth that I desire besides you. My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever" (vv. 25-26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a creed: “Truly God is good.” Then the psalmist admits that he almost lost it. He looked at the wicked, who had no pangs and bodies that were fat and sleek, free from trouble, mocking God, and he envied them. He wondered whether his own faithfulness had been pointless. “All in vain have I kept my heart clean.” Many believers have felt this. The Bible lets us say it out loud.

The turning point is a small phrase: “until I went into the sanctuary of God.” The solution to his problem was not a better argument, but worship. In God’s presence, he saw the whole picture: “then I discerned their end.” The wicked are on slippery ground and will be destroyed in a moment. They are like a dream when one awakes. What looked solid is a vapor. Perspective changes everything when we see it from God’s point of view.

The psalmist then confesses how foolish he had been: “I was brutish and ignorant; I was like a beast toward you.” His envy had been irrational. But he does not stop there. His confession leads to the greatest statement of the psalm: “Nevertheless, I am continually with you; you hold my right hand.” The “nevertheless” is the pivot. Despite his ignorance, God held him. His security rests not on his grip on God but on God’s grip on him.

Verses 25 and 26 are among the most beautiful in the Bible. “Whom have I in heaven but you?” God himself is the treasure. “My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever.” The psalmist ends by saying, “For me it is good to be near God.” This is the answer to the problem of the prosperity of the wicked: God himself is the reward. And with that, the psalmist sees that the wicked, though rich, have nothing.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “What does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?” (Mark 8:36). The sanctuary where the psalmist found perspective is fulfilled in Christ, in whom we have access to God (Hebrews 10:19-22). The poor man Lazarus and the rich man (Luke 16:19-31) illustrate verses 17 to 20. Philippians 3:8 expresses the same treasure: “I count everything as loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord.”

STEP 6

Application

Think about whom you have envied. Bring it into the sanctuary of God and ask for his perspective.

Pray verses 25 and 26 slowly, and ask whether they are true for you.

When you feel like you are slipping, remember that God holds your right hand.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess your envy of those who seem to prosper.
- Tell him what you see differently in his presence.
- Tell him he is the strength of your heart and your portion.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 326 · WEEK 47

Ecclesiastes 5:1-7:29

Fear God; wealth's emptiness; wisdom's limits

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ecclesiastes 5:1-7:29. These chapters include advice on worship, the problem of wealth, and reflections on wisdom and death. Notice the practical tone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Preacher shifts from observation to counsel. After describing the futility of life under the sun, he offers advice on how to live well within it. He speaks of approaching God, the limits of wealth, and the value of mourning. The tone is sober, and the advice is realistic. It is the voice of an experienced teacher.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Guard your steps when you go to the house of God. To draw near to listen is better than to offer the sacrifice of fools" (5:1).
2. "God is in heaven and you are on earth. Therefore let your words be few" (5:2).
3. "He who loves money will not be satisfied with money, nor he who loves wealth with his income" (5:10).
4. "As he came from his mother's womb he shall go again, naked as he came, and shall take nothing for his toil" (5:15).
5. "Every man also to whom God has given wealth and possessions and power to enjoy them, and to accept his lot and rejoice in his toil, this is the gift of God" (5:19).
6. "It is better to go to the house of mourning than to go to the house of feasting, for this is the end of all mankind, and the living will lay it to heart" (7:2).

7. “In the day of prosperity be joyful, and in the day of adversity consider: God has made the one as well as the other” (7:14).

8. “Surely there is no one on earth who is righteous, who does good and never sins” (7:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Preacher begins with worship. “Guard your steps when you go to the house of God.” He warns against thoughtless religion: hurried words, empty vows, and the “sacrifice of fools.” To listen is better than to offer. “God is in heaven and you are on earth. Therefore let your words be few.” It is the posture of reverence. We approach a holy God with humility and attention, not with a flood of words.

The long section on wealth makes several observations. Money does not satisfy: “He who loves money will not be satisfied.” The more one has, the more people there are to consume it. Wealth can be lost in a bad venture. And at death, one leaves with nothing. The Preacher has no patience for the idea that riches bring security. Yet he does not say wealth is evil. The gift is that God enables a person to enjoy what he has. “This is the gift of God.” The ability to enjoy is itself a gift.

Chapter 7 gathers a series of “better than” sayings that seem strange at first. Better to go to the house of mourning than to a feast. Better sorrow than laughter. Better the rebuke of a wise man than the song of fools. The reason is that grief teaches. A funeral reminds us of the end and makes us wise. Those who avoid thinking about death live carelessly.

The Preacher gives an honest comment on the limits of wisdom. He tried to be wise, but it was “far from me.” He admits that there is much he cannot understand. He also says that God has made both prosperity and adversity, and that we cannot predict the future. The wise do not demand to know everything.

The chapter ends with a sober statement of human sinfulness: “No one on earth is righteous, who does good and never sins.” And with a key diagnosis: “God made man upright, but they have sought out many schemes.” The problem is not creation but the Fall.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Ecclesiastes 7:20 in the same spirit in Romans 3:10-12. Jesus warned against empty words in prayer (Matthew 6:7). 1 Timothy 6:6-10 says that godliness with contentment is great gain, and that the love of money is the root of all kinds of evils. Jesus said, “Blessed are those who mourn” (Matthew 5:4). He is the one who is without sin (Hebrews 4:15), the righteous one the Preacher could not find.

STEP 6

Application

Before your next time of worship or prayer, slow down. Listen before you speak.

Ask whether money is satisfying you or driving you. Practice contentment today.

Sit with mortality for a few minutes. What does it teach you about how to live?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to teach you to listen more than you speak.
- Ask him to keep you from loving money.
- Tell him where you want to be satisfied in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 327 · WEEK 47

Ecclesiastes 8:1-10:20

Wisdom and rulers; death levels all; folly's cost

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ecclesiastes 8:1-10:20. The Preacher considers the injustice of life, the fate of death that comes to all, and the limits of human wisdom. Read with patience. These are some of the book's hardest passages.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Preacher continues his reflection with an eye on rulers and justice. He sees that the wicked sometimes prosper and the righteous suffer, that death comes to everyone, and that wisdom does not always bring rewards. At the same time, he repeatedly calls the reader to enjoy life as a gift. These chapters are among the most puzzling and most honest in the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Though a sinner does evil a hundred times and prolongs his life, yet I know that it will be well with those who fear God" (8:12).
2. "There is a vanity that takes place on earth, that there are righteous people to whom it happens according to the deeds of the wicked" (8:14).
3. "It is the same for all, since the same event happens to the righteous and the wicked" (9:2).
4. "A living dog is better than a dead lion" (9:4).
5. "Go, eat your bread with joy, and drink your wine with a merry heart, for God has already approved what you do" (9:7).
6. "Whatever your hand finds to do, do it with your might, for there is no work or thought or knowledge or wisdom in Sheol, to which you are going" (9:10).

7. “The race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong… but time and chance happen to them all” (9:11).

8. “Dead flies make the perfumer’s ointment give off a stench; so a little folly outweighs wisdom and honor” (10:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Preacher is troubled by injustice. He sees wicked people buried with honor, and righteous people receiving what the wicked deserve. “There is a vanity that takes place on earth.” He does not hide it. Yet he holds fast to a central conviction: “It will be well with those who fear God.” He cannot see how, but he knows that God is just. This is faith in the dark.

Chapter 9 faces death head-on. The same fate comes to all. The living know they will die, but the dead know nothing. Our loves and hates and envies perish. This is how it looks from “under the sun,” the perspective of observation without revelation. The Preacher is describing the limits of what can be seen. He does not yet have the fullness of the resurrection hope.

Yet in the face of death, he gives a surprising command: enjoy life. “Go, eat your bread with joy.” Enjoy your wife, “all the days of your vain life.” And “whatever your hand finds to do, do it with your might.” The shortness of life is not a reason for despair but for diligence and joy. Because we will not be here forever, we should live fully now and work wholeheartedly.

He also says that life is not predictable: “The race is not to the swift.” Time and chance happen to everyone. We cannot guarantee outcomes. The Preacher does not deny God’s sovereignty, but he refuses to turn the proverbs into promises. Wisdom is valuable, but no one can control how things turn out.

Chapter 10 returns to the practical, with sayings about folly and rulers. A little folly spoils much wisdom. “The words of a wise man’s mouth win him favor, but the lips of a fool consume him.” The chapter shows that wisdom matters even though it does not guarantee success.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that Christ has “abolished death and brought life and immortality to light through the gospel” (2 Timothy 1:10), answering the Preacher’s darkness. 1 Corinthians 15:58 says, “Your labor is not in vain in the Lord.” Jesus spoke of working “while it is day” (John 9:4). Colossians 3:23 echoes 9:10: “Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord.” Revelation 14:13 says the dead who die in the Lord rest from their labors and their deeds follow them.

STEP 6

Application

Enjoy one simple pleasure today, with thanks to God.

Do a task you have been avoiding with all your might.

If you are troubled by injustice, bring it to God, who is just even when you cannot see it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God what you do not understand about life under the sun.

Ask him to teach you to enjoy his gifts with thanks and humility.

Ask him to keep you from folly's small costs.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 328 · WEEK 47

Ecclesiastes 11:1-12:14

Remember your Creator; fear God and keep his commandments

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ecclesiastes 11:1-12:14. The Preacher's final words call the young to remember their Creator, describe old age, and give the conclusion of the whole book. Read the last two verses slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The book comes to its end. After exploring the vanity of life under the sun, the Preacher now speaks to the young, then to the old, and then gives his closing verdict. An unnamed editor adds a few words about the Preacher. The conclusion is the key to the entire book and answers the question "What is the point?"

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Cast your bread upon the waters, for you will find it after many days" (11:1).
2. "As you do not know the way the spirit comes to the bones in the womb of a woman with child, so you do not know the work of God who makes everything" (11:5).
3. "Rejoice, O young man, in your youth, and let your heart cheer you in the days of your youth... But know that for all these things God will bring you into judgment" (11:9).
4. "Remember also your Creator in the days of your youth, before the evil days come" (12:1).
5. The poem of old age: the keepers of the house tremble, the grinders cease, the almond tree blossoms, the silver cord is snapped (12:3-6).
6. "And the dust returns to the earth as it was, and the spirit returns to God who gave it" (12:7).

7 “The words of the wise are like goads, and like nails firmly fixed are the collected sayings; they are given by one Shepherd” (12:11).

8 “The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man. For God will bring every deed into judgment, with every secret thing, whether good or evil” (12:13-14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 11 is an encouragement to generosity and bold action. “Cast your bread upon the waters.” Take risks in giving and investing, because you cannot know what will come. The one who waits for perfect conditions never sows or reaps. We cannot know the work of God, so we should act in faith and diligence. “In the morning sow your seed, and at evening withhold not your hand.”

The Preacher then speaks to the young. “Rejoice in your youth.” He does not tell the young to be glum. But he adds a sobering note: God will bring you into judgment. Joy and accountability go together. And in chapter 12, he gives the command: “Remember your Creator in the days of your youth.” Do it before it is too late, before the “evil days” of old age come.

The poem on old age is one of the most moving in the Bible. It describes a house falling apart: the trembling of the arms, the stooping of the legs, the loss of teeth, dimming eyes, deafness, fear of heights, white hair, and finally death, when “the silver cord is snapped.” It is a vivid portrait of how bodies fail. Its purpose is not morbid but sobering: remember your Creator now.

The last words give the book’s conclusion: “Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man.” After exploring everything under the sun, the Preacher returns to the theme that began Proverbs. The answer to vanity is not found in more experience but in the fear of God. And life matters because “God will bring every deed into judgment.” Nothing is meaningless, because everything will be seen and weighed by him.

Verse 11 says that the words of the wise are like goads and nails, given by “one Shepherd.” The book of Ecclesiastes, with its challenging honesty, is part of God’s shepherding word. It pushes us toward what matters.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says, “The fear of the Lord” and judgment are intertwined: “We must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ” (2 Corinthians 5:10). Jesus is the “one Shepherd” (John 10:11, 16), the Good Shepherd who gives us the words of life. “Remember your Creator” echoes Mark 10:14-15 and 2 Timothy 3:15. The “whole duty of man” is fulfilled in Christ, who kept the commandments perfectly, and in whom we are forgiven (Romans 8:3-4).

STEP 6

Application

Do something generous without waiting for the perfect time.

If you are young, remember your Creator now. If you are older, tell someone younger what you have learned.

Write down the Preacher’s conclusion, and ask what it means for how you spend this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Remember your Creator in your own words, and thank him for something from your youth or now.
- Ask him to teach you to fear him and keep his commandments.
- Thank Jesus, the Good Shepherd.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

“The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man.”

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 329 · WEEK 47

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ecclesiastes 12:13 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

REST

Meditation

This verse is the Preacher's final answer. After twelve chapters of searching, he arrives at a conclusion that is as simple as it is demanding.

"The end of the matter; all has been heard." The Preacher says that he has finished. All the observations, experiments, and puzzles have been laid out. Now comes the summary. It is a way of saying: if you want only one thing from this book, take this.

"Fear God." The book began with "vanity," and it ends with "fear." The Preacher's long reflection shows that nothing under the sun can bear the weight of our hopes. The only stable footing is a right relationship to the God who made us. To fear God is to honor him as God, to trust him, to submit to him, and to take him seriously.

“And keep his commandments.” Fear is not just a feeling. It shows itself in obedience. The two belong together. A person who says he fears God but ignores what God says has not understood.

“For this is the whole duty of man.” The Hebrew is literally “this is the whole of man.” This is what a human being is for. It is the purpose of our existence. All the things we chase, if they are not oriented to this, are a breath.

The verse that follows adds a motive: God will bring every deed into judgment. This is both a warning and a comfort. Nothing is hidden, and nothing is wasted. For the Christian, the weight of this verse is carried by Christ. He kept God’s commandments perfectly, and he bore the judgment we deserved. We now fear God not as condemned people but as forgiven children, and we obey out of gratitude. Pray this verse as a summary of your life’s purpose.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you moved from Proverbs into the heart of Ecclesiastes. You saw the Preacher’s verdict on life under the sun: vanity of vanities, a breath. You read the poem of times and the promise that God has put eternity into our hearts. You read the Psalter’s answers to the same questions: Psalm 49, in which God ransoms the soul from Sheol, and Psalm 73, where the psalmist’s near-slip ended in the sanctuary and in the great confession, “Whom have I in heaven but you?” You followed the Preacher’s counsel on worship, wealth, mourning, and mortality, and his call to enjoy life as a gift and to work with all your might. And you reached the end of the matter: fear God and keep his commandments. The week taught that nothing under the sun satisfies, that death is real, and that God himself is our portion.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Preacher says God has “put eternity into man’s heart.” Where do you feel that longing for something more, and how does it point you to God?

Psalm 49 says no one can ransom another, but God will ransom the faithful from Sheol. How does Jesus fulfill this promise, and how does it change how you think about death?

Psalm 73 says, “Whom have I in heaven but you?” If you honestly answer that question today, what do you find?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to fear him and keep his commandments.

Thank Christ for the ransom.

Rest in him as the strength of your heart.

DAY 330 · WEEK 48

Song of Solomon 1:1–4:16

Love, desire, and covenant

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 68 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Song of Solomon 1:1-4:16. This is a love poem between a man and a woman. Read it slowly, as poetry. Do not rush to allegory or avoid it as embarrassing. First, let it be what it is.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Song of Songs, "which is Solomon's," means "the best song." It is a collection of love poems in dialogue between a bride, a bridegroom, and a chorus of friends, the "daughters of Jerusalem." It celebrates erotic love within marriage. It is placed here because the wisdom books explore how to live well in God's world, and a good marriage is one of the central gifts. The song has also been read throughout church history as a picture of Christ's love for his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth! For your love is better than wine" (1:2).
2. "I am black and lovely, O daughters of Jerusalem" (1:5).
3. "As a lily among brambles, so is my love among the young women" (2:2).
4. "He brought me to the banqueting house, and his banner over me was love" (2:4).
5. "My beloved is mine, and I am his" (2:16).
6. "I adjure you, O daughters of Jerusalem… that you not stir up or awaken love until it pleases" (2:7).
7. "You are altogether beautiful, my love; there is no flaw in you" (4:7).
8. "A garden locked is my sister, my bride, a spring locked, a fountain sealed" (4:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Song begins with desire. The woman speaks first, and her words are bold. She longs for her beloved's kisses. The Bible does not shy away from the physical side of love. The Song presents it as a good gift of God, to be celebrated within the covenant of marriage. In a world that treats sex either as shameful or as trivial, the Song says it is beautiful and holy.

The couple exchange compliments in rich poetic images that can sound strange to modern ears: eyes like doves, hair like a flock of goats, a nose like a tower of Lebanon. These were images of beauty and delight in the ancient world. The man praises the woman's beauty, and the woman praises his. They value each other. The mutuality is striking.

The refrain of 2:7, "Do not stir up or awaken love until it pleases," appears three times in the Song. It is a warning to the daughters of Jerusalem: love should not be forced or rushed. It has a time. This is a wise word for a culture that hurries into physical intimacy. Love is powerful, and it should be treated with care.

In chapter 2, the poem moves to spring. "For behold, the winter is past; the rain is over and gone. The flowers appear on the earth." Love is like the renewal of the earth. There are scenes of longing and search, of delight in the other's presence. The woman says, "My beloved is mine, and I am his." It is a statement of covenant belonging.

Chapter 3 includes a dream or search at night and the wedding procession of Solomon. Chapter 4 is the groom's long praise of his bride on their wedding night. The garden imagery, "a garden locked," speaks of purity and exclusivity. And the bride's response is an invitation: "Let my beloved come to his garden, and eat its choicest fruits." Love is both reserved and freely given.

STEP 5

Connection

Christian readers have long seen in the Song a picture of Christ and his church. Ephesians 5:25-32 calls marriage a profound mystery pointing to Christ and the church. John 3:29 says, "The one who has the bride is the bridegroom." Revelation 19:7 describes the marriage of the Lamb. At the same time, the Song stands as a celebration of human marriage in its own right. Jesus affirmed marriage as God's design from the beginning (Matthew 19:4-6).

STEP 6

Application

If you are married, speak words of praise to your spouse today.

If you are single, thank God for the gift of marriage as a picture of Christ's love.

Ask God to help you honor desire in the right time and place.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for love and for the picture of Christ and his church in marriage.

Ask him to teach you to value what he has given in its proper time.

Pray for those who are lonely or married, as it fits.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 48

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

DAY 331 · WEEK 48

Song of Solomon 5:1-8:14

Longing, union, and love strong as death

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Song of Solomon 5:1-8:14. The mood becomes more complex, with longing, loss, and the great declaration about love in chapter 8. Read 8:6-7 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second half of the Song continues the cycle of love poems. There is delight, but also absence and search. The woman dreams of her beloved knocking at the door and then disappearing. She searches the city and is beaten by the watchmen. The couple reunite, and the poem moves toward its conclusion with one of the most famous statements about love in all literature.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “I slept, but my heart was awake. A sound! My beloved is knocking” (5:2).
2. “I opened to my beloved, but my beloved had turned and gone” (5:6).
3. “My beloved is radiant and ruddy, distinguished among ten thousand” (5:10).
4. “I am my beloved’s and my beloved is mine; he grazes among the lilies” (6:3).
5. “Come away, my beloved, let us go out into the fields” (7:11).
6. “Set me as a seal upon your heart, as a seal upon your arm, for love is strong as death, jealousy is fierce as the grave” (8:6).
7. “Its flashes are flashes of fire, the very flame of the LORD” (8:6).
8. “Many waters cannot quench love, neither can floods drown it. If a man offered for love all the wealth of his house, he would be utterly despised” (8:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 5 opens with a scene of near-miss. The woman is in bed, and her beloved knocks, but she hesitates. By the time she opens the door, he is gone. She searches the streets and is struck by the watchmen. It is a picture of the pain of missed connection, and perhaps of the way that love can be strained by hesitation. The daughters of Jerusalem ask what is so special about her beloved, and she answers with a long praise. Love is not blind. She can say exactly why he is distinguished among ten thousand.

The poem describes reconciliation. “I am my beloved’s and my beloved is mine.” The repeated phrase is a statement of covenant belonging. In chapter 6 the man praises her as “terrible as an army with banners,” awe-inspiring. In chapter 7, the couple expresses desire and delight in the language of the vineyard and the garden. The woman invites him to the field, where she will give him her love.

The center of the whole Song is 8:6-7. “Set me as a seal upon your heart.” A seal was a mark of ownership and a pledge of identity. She wants to be marked as his, permanently. “For love is strong as death.” Death cannot be resisted. Neither can love. “Jealousy is fierce as the grave.” This is the jealousy of covenant love, which cannot share its beloved. And “its flashes are flashes of fire, the very flame of the LORD.” Some versions read, “a flame of Yah.” Love is a spark of the divine. It is one of the only places in the Song where God’s name appears.

“Many waters cannot quench love.” It is the kind of love that endures floods. And it cannot be bought. If a man tried to purchase it with all his wealth, he would be despised. Love is a gift, not a commodity.

The Song ends with the woman’s invitation: “Make haste, my beloved.” It is a note of longing that is not fully satisfied. Love in this world points beyond itself.

STEP 5

Connection

The words about love strong as death find their fullest meaning in Christ’s love, which defeated death. “Greater love has no one than this” (John 15:13). Romans 8:35-39 says that nothing, neither death nor life, can separate us from the love of God in Christ. Paul says in Ephesians 5 that Christ gave himself for his bride. Revelation 22:17 and 20 echo the final invitation: “Come, Lord Jesus.” The seal on the heart recalls Ephesians 1:13, where believers are “sealed with the promised Holy Spirit.”

STEP 6

Application

If you are married, renew your commitment to your spouse. Say, “I am yours.”

Ask God to help you love with a love that endures floods.

Think about the love of Christ, which was stronger than death, and rest in it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Christ for giving himself for his bride.
- Ask him to set you as a seal on his heart, and tell him what that means.
- Tell him where you long for him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 48

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

DAY 332 · WEEK 48

Psalm 45

The bridal song and its Messianic echo

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 45. You read this psalm in Unit 9, with attention to the king. Today read it again, this time paying special attention to the bride in verses 10 to 17 and to how the psalm echoes the Song of Solomon.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 45 is a royal wedding song, and in Unit 9 (Day 290) you read it as a portrait of the Davidic king. Now it appears at the close of the wisdom books, right after the Song of Solomon. The two works belong together. Both celebrate a royal wedding and a bridegroom's love, and both have been read by the church as a picture of Christ and his people. This time, look at the bride.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "My heart overflows with a pleasing theme; I address my verses to the king" (v. 1).
2. "Your throne, O God, is forever and ever" (v. 6).
3. "At your right hand stands the queen in gold of Ophir" (v. 9).
4. "Hear, O daughter, consider, and incline your ear: forget your people and your father's house" (v. 10).
5. "and the king will desire your beauty. Since he is your lord, bow to him" (v. 11).
6. "All glorious is the princess in her chamber, with robes interwoven with gold" (v. 13).
7. "With joy and gladness they are led along as they enter the palace of the king" (v. 15).
8. "I will cause your name to be remembered in all generations; therefore nations will praise you forever and ever" (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Unit 9 the focus was on the king: his majesty, his righteousness, and his eternal throne. Here the focus shifts to the bride. She is told to forget her people and her father's house. A wedding means leaving one family to join another. It echoes Genesis 2:24: "A man shall leave his father and his mother and hold fast to his wife." She is called to a new loyalty. The call is not a loss but a gain, because "the king will desire your beauty." Her beauty is a gift of his love.

The bride is clothed in splendor. She stands at the king's right hand in gold. She is led to the king in embroidered garments, with companions, with joy and gladness. The picture is not of a servant but of a queen. In the Song of Solomon, we saw the same mutual delight of the bridegroom and bride. In both texts, love is a covenant that transforms and glorifies.

Reading with the Song in mind, we notice how both works use the language of royalty and beauty to speak of love. The bridegroom is a king, and the bride is a queen. The ordinary becomes extraordinary. A wedding is a picture of how God loves his people.

The psalm closes with a promise concerning the king's name: "Nations will praise you forever." The love story of the king extends to the nations. What began as a royal wedding becomes a universal blessing.

Read with the whole Bible, the psalm points to Christ the King and his bride the church, a love that began in a promise and ends in a wedding feast. The wisdom books end with love, which is the end of wisdom: knowing and being known by God.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 5:25-27 says that Christ loved the church and gave himself for her, "that he might present the church to himself in splendor." Revelation 19:7-8 shows the bride arrayed in fine linen, bright and pure. Revelation 21:2 pictures the New Jerusalem "prepared as a bride adorned for her husband." Hebrews 1:8-9 quotes verses 6 and 7 of this psalm of the Son. Jesus is the Bridegroom (Mark 2:19-20).

STEP 6

Application

Read verse 10 as a call to give your first loyalty to Christ. What does "forget your father's house" mean for you?

Thank God that the Bridegroom desires his people.

Think about how the church is being prepared for the wedding. How can you take part?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what fills your heart as you think of the King and his bride.

Ask him to teach you to give Christ your first loyalty.

Ask him to prepare his church for his coming.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 48

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

DAY 333 · WEEK 48

Review and Reflection

Unit 10 review, Wisdom Literature

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."
>
> PROVERBS 3:5-6

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 10.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Say it aloud several times, then try writing it from memory. These verses have been the anchor of this unit, and they sum up the instruction of the wisdom books.

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart." Wisdom begins with trust, not with technique. In Proverbs, we saw that the fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom. Trust is the same posture seen from the inside. We believe that God is good and that he knows what he is doing.

"And do not lean on your own understanding." Ecclesiastes shows what happens when we do. The Preacher explored the world with all his intelligence and found it a vapor. Psalm 73 shows a man who nearly fell because he trusted what he saw. The way that seems right to a man ends in death. Our understanding is not useless, but it cannot be our final authority.

"In all your ways acknowledge him." Not only in church, but in work, money, marriage, friendships, speech, and decisions. This is the lived side of wisdom: bringing God into everything.

“And he will make straight your paths.” This is a promise. It does not say the path will be easy. It says that God will direct it. The Song of Solomon reminds us that his love is stronger than death. The Preacher ends with fear God and keep his commandments. The Psalms say that God holds our right hand.

Think of Christ, who trusted the Father perfectly and did not lean on his own understanding, and who is himself the wisdom of God. In him, the paths of all who trust are made straight.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 10 you have read the wisdom books of the Old Testament: Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, and the Song of Solomon, along with Psalms 19, 45, 49, 73, and a long journey through Psalm 119. If the story of Israel’s history showed how God rules his people, these books show how to live in the world God made.

Proverbs opened with the fear of the LORD as the beginning of knowledge, and called the reader to choose between the way of Wisdom and the way of Folly. You read the father’s instruction to his son, the warnings about adultery, laziness, and bad company, and the beautiful alternative of faithful love. You read Wisdom’s own speech in chapter 8, where she stands beside God at creation, a poetic picture that the New Testament sees fulfilled in Christ. You read hundreds of sayings on speech, work, friendship, justice, generosity, and pride, and saw that God holds human plans in his hand. The book ended with Agur’s humility and the portrait of the excellent wife, whose praise rests on the fear of the LORD.

Ecclesiastes asked the hard questions. The Preacher looked at life under the sun and found it a breath. He tried pleasure, work, and wisdom, and found that death comes to all. Yet he did not despair. He called us to receive life as a gift from God, to enjoy and to work, and to remember that God will bring every deed into judgment. His conclusion was simple: fear God and keep his commandments. Psalms 49 and 73 gave the hope the Preacher could only glimpse: God will ransom the soul from Sheol, and he himself is our portion.

The Song of Solomon celebrated love between husband and wife as a good gift from God, and a picture of the love between Christ and his church. Its great declaration was that love is strong as death. Psalm 119 offered a long meditation on the word of God as a lamp, honey, and light. And Psalm 45 closed the unit with the royal wedding.

Together these books teach that God is not only the Lord of history but the Lord of ordinary life. They also leave us longing for the one in whom all wisdom dwells.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What is the “fear of the LORD” and why is it the beginning of wisdom?

Look back at Proverbs 1:7, 9:10, and the closing of Ecclesiastes. The fear of the LORD is reverent trust: taking God seriously as God. Write a few sentences describing what it means, and how it differs from terror. Why is it the starting point rather than an add-on? How does the cross show both the reason to fear and the reason to trust?

How does Ecclesiastes’s conclusion answer the problem of vanity?

Recall the Preacher’s long exploration of work, pleasure, wealth, and wisdom, and his verdict that all is a breath. Then recall his final words: fear God and keep his commandments, for God will bring every deed into judgment. Write about how this conclusion answers the problem. Where is the hope in the book, and where does it point beyond itself to Christ?

How does Wisdom in Proverbs 8 point us toward Christ?

Look at Proverbs 8:22-31, where Wisdom speaks of being beside God as a master workman at creation. Compare it with John 1:1-3, Colossians 1:15-17, and 1 Corinthians 1:24. Write a few sentences on how the New Testament reads this passage, and what it means that Christ is the wisdom of God. How does this change how you seek wisdom?

What is the Song of Solomon ultimately about, and how should we read it?

Think about the Song as a celebration of married love, and then about the church’s long tradition of seeing in it a picture of Christ and his people. Look at Ephesians 5:25-32. Write a few sentences on how both readings can be held together. What does the Song teach about the goodness of desire, the value of covenant, and the strength of love?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for what the wisdom books have taught you.

Tell him where you still lean on your own understanding.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.